

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Medieval History 07

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate | Cross-dynastic thematic synthesis | 1206-1526

Administration

- Sultan, offices, iqta, audit, army
- and intelligence changed across dynasties.
- Centralisation always relied on provincial and village intermediaries.

Economy

- Agrarian surplus, towns, currency, trade, crafts and technology
- formed a military-fiscal economy.
- Growth and coercion coexisted.

Society

- Nobles, peasants, artisans, merchants, ulama, Sufis, slaves
- and women experienced rule unevenly.
- Avoid static binaries.

How to read the topic

Best exam formula: Persianate military-fiscal state at the apex
-> negotiated sovereignty below -> regional and social unevenness throughout. Read court chroniclers, coins, inscriptions, architecture and later textbooks separately before synthesising.

Topic-specific cover: state formation, agrarian surplus, towns, law and society change together.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate - Complete Topic Package

Medieval History 07

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate | Cross-dynastic thematic synthesis | 1206-1526

Administration

- Sultan, offices, iqta, audit, army
- and intelligence changed across dynasties.
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- and women experienced rule unevenly.
- Avoid static binaries.

How to read the topic

Best exam formula: Persianate military-fiscal state at the apex
-> negotiated sovereignty below
-> regional and social unevenness throughout. Read court chroniclers, coins, inscriptions, architecture and later textbooks separately before synthesising.

Topic-specific cover: state formation, agrarian surplus, towns, law and society change together.

Sultanate administration economy and society cover

Subject: Medieval Indian History | **Topic:** 07 | **Export date:** 2026-08-16 **Approval:** false - awaiting explicit user approval. **Source order:** repository Markdown -> local OCR-searchable Satish Chandra concise volume and Part I Sultanate chapters -> bounded repository source-bank on Topics 01 and 03-06 plus Topic 10 and Topic 11 where ownership requires controlled borrowing -> no forced live current-affairs insert -> Qdrant not used. **Tag rule:** [FACT] source-grounded statement; [ANALYSIS] evidence-led synthesis; [DEBATE] historiographical disagreement or category caution; [LIMIT] evidentiary, chronological or regional qualification.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete Medieval History Core is taught before optional enrichment.
Evidence method	Claim -> named site/text/inscription/coin/example -> analysis -> qualification.
Source hierarchy	Archaeology, textual testimony, inscriptions, coins and scholarly interpretation remain visibly distinct.
Contested issues	Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced and bounded; certainty is not manufactured.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, an examiner-grade model, an executable answer/compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

Canonical Basic/Core owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Medieval-Indian-History\basic\07_Sultanate-Administration-Economy-Society.md **Canonical topic owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Medieval-Indian-History\basic\07_Sultanate-Administration-Economy-Society.md **Optional Advanced owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Medieval-Indian-History\advanced\07_Sultanate-Administration-Economy-Society.md **Official syllabus mapping:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\Medieval-Indian-History\OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Archaeological inference:** material context supports bounded reconstruction; absence is not automatic proof of non-existence.
- **Textual testimony:** genre, authorship, redaction, patronage and temporal distance control what a text can prove.
- **Inscription and coin evidence:** contemporary names, titles, claims and circulation are powerful but do not by themselves map uniform territorial control.
- **Scholarly interpretation:** historian labels are arguments to test, not facts to memorise without evidence.
- **PYQ discipline:** repository ledgers and locally held official papers control wording and metadata; reconstructed wording and unavailable official keys must be labelled.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-03:** The Reserve Bank of India's Medieval India coinage page was rechecked on 30 August 2026. It describes the consolidation of the tanka and jittal, an attempted standardisation under the Delhi Sultanate, expansion of the money economy and gold, silver and copper issues. This official numismatic bridge supports the package's coinage and monetisation section; its estimates and evaluative language are identified as RBI museum-page claims rather than universal measures of social welfare or uniform market penetration.

Live/primary context sources recorded by the predecessor generation:

- <https://www.rbi.org.in/commonman/English/Currency/Scripts/Medieval.aspx>



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

Package counts, provenance and honest limitations

- Learning sections: 24; learning MCQ loops: 18.

- Workbook content: 4 verified or honestly-adjacent solved PYQs; 32 original broad-coverage MCQs; 12 remedial trap MCQs; 6 original solved Mains questions; final register modules: 13.
- Original PNG visuals: 31 total - 30 body visuals plus 1 topic-specific cover visual. All route and hierarchy diagrams are schematic and not to scale.
- Repository sources used most heavily: Topic 07 basic and advanced owners; bounded Topics 01, 03, 04, 05, 06, 10 and 11; README.md; 00_Master-Chronology.md; REVISION-CHART_Ages-Eras-and-Distinctive-Features.md; ANSWER-WORTHINESS-AUDIT.md; PYQ routing ledgers; and the already-generated Medieval 03-06 packages for house style, source discipline and overlap control.
- OCR evidence used most heavily from Satish Chandra's *History of Medieval India* chapter "Government, and Economic and Social Life" and from *Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I* chapters on centralised monarchy, government and administration, economic and social life in north India, and the nature of the state under the Sultanate.
- [LIMIT] Local OCR is strong on offices, iqta, revenue demand, traders, craft change, slavery and social hierarchy, but weaker on exact local micro-chronology below the province. Accordingly, terms such as *pargana*, *qanungo* and even *zamindar* are used with chronology caution rather than projected automatically into every reign.
- [LIMIT] The package does not use precise production figures, trade volumes, fixed tax rates for every reign, or dramatic demographic counts unsupported by the local source base. When a chronicle number or later label is insecure, the package says so.
- [LIMIT] Categories such as *ashraf*, *ajlaf* and especially *arzal* are useful for signalling social differentiation within Muslim society, but they are not treated as timeless census boxes for the whole Sultanate. Their chronology and source setting are kept explicit.
- [LIMIT] Topic 07 owns the cross-dynastic thematic synthesis. Political biographies in detail remain with Topics 03-06, regional kingdoms with Topics 08-09, Bhakti-Sufi movements with Topic 10, and the full architecture survey with Topic 11.

Sources actually used

Source class	Exact source	Use and caveat
Repository knowledge	Topic 07 basic and advanced owners; bounded Topics 01, 03, 04, 05, 06, 10 and 11; Medieval README; Master Chronology; Revision Chart; Answer-Worthiness Audit; PYQ ledgers; prior complete packages for Topics 03-06.	Controlled chronology, topic boundaries, correction of older textbook overstatement, and exact repository semantics on offices, technology, fanam, Persian sources and local caution.
Local book	Satish Chandra, <i>History of Medieval India</i> , searchable OCR around the printed chapter "Government, and Economic and Social Life".	Core evidence for the ministries, iqta, village hierarchy, towns, merchants, paper-making, spinning wheel, slavery, caste and the formal Islamic-but-pragmatic character of the state.
Local book	Satish Chandra, <i>Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I (Delhi Sultanat, 1206-1526)</i> , searchable OCR around printed pp. 136-171 and the state chapter.	Deeper evidence for mushrif/mustaufi checks, diwan-i-risalat caution, ashraf-ajlaf language, hundis, Persian-knowing Hindus, new landed gentry, and the debate over state character.
Source families through source-critical repository synthesis	Minhaj, Barani, Amir Khusrau, Ibn Battuta, Isami, Afif, coins, inscriptions and architecture.	Used for answer architecture and evidentiary discipline. Court bias, chronology distance and literary agenda are flagged rather than hidden.
Live source	None required for completion.	A historical package of this kind was fully supportable from repository Markdown and local OCR-searchable books; no decorative current-affairs hook was forced into the topic.

Original visual asset index

- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/07_Administration-Economy-Society-under-the-Sultanate/00_sultanate_admin_economy_society_cover.png
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- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/07_Administration-Economy-Society-under-the-Sul tanate/30_gs1_answer_spine.png

SESSION 1 - SCOPE, FRAMING AND CHRONOLOGY DISCIPLINE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The best exam-safe frame is changing, negotiated and regionally uneven rule.

Technical definition: Topic 07 spans the Delhi Sultanate from its thirteenth-century consolidation to the Lodi transition, but it does so through institutions, revenue, markets, social hierarchy and historiography rather than by repeating ruler-biographies already owned by Topics 03-06.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Topic 07 spans the Delhi Sultanate from its thirteenth-century consolidation to the Lodi transition, but it does so through institutions, revenue, markets, social hierarchy and historiography rather than by repeating ruler-biographies already owned by Topics 03-06.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Scope
- framing
- chronology discipline
- changing, negotiated and regionally uneven rule
- Topics 03-06
- Topic 08-09

How to use them: Frame the answer through Scope; define framing, connect chronology discipline with changing, negotiated and regionally uneven rule to explain the mechanism, and use Topics 03-06 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Topic 07 spans the Delhi Sultanate from its thirteenth-century consolidation to the Lodi transition, but it does so through institutions, revenue, markets, social hierarchy and historiography rather than by repeating ruler-biographies already owned by Topics 03-06.

[ANALYSIS] The best exam-safe frame is **changing, negotiated and regionally uneven rule**. Mamluk consolidation, Khalji tightening, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's over-centralising experiments, Firuz's softer audit and hereditary drift, and the Sayyid-Lodi rebalancing all altered how administration, economy and society worked.

[DEBATE] Three distortions must be blocked at the beginning: the idea of a fully uniform modern bureaucracy; the idea of a timeless Islamic state whose legal language automatically governed all practice; and the idea of a static Hindu-Muslim social binary with no shared administrative or economic spaces.

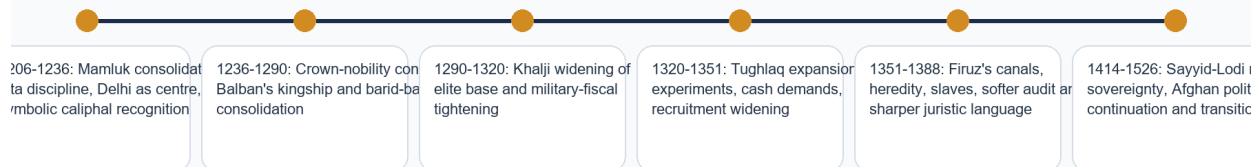
[LIMIT] Source form matters. Court chroniclers, travellers, coins, inscriptions and architecture illuminate different layers. Therefore the package separates normative Persian vocabulary, chronicler claims, actual administration and later textbook generalisation before drawing conclusions.

Topic ownership firewall

Owner	What remains primarily there	What Topic 07 legitimately uses
Topics 03-06	Mamluk, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid and Lodi political narratives in full	Only bounded ruler-specific examples needed to explain institutional change
Topic 08-09	Bengal, Gujarat, Malwa, Jaunpur, Kashmir, Vijayanagara and Bahmani in depth	Only regional illustrations proving that Delhi's institutions always met local variation
Topic 10	Bhakti and Sufi movements in detail	Only the limited social and political relevance of ulema-Sufi-state interaction
Topic 11	Full architecture survey and style-history	Only technology, urban building demand and the evidentiary value of monuments

Thematic chronology and institution evolution spine

Institutional shifts matter more than ruler-lists.



Institutional chronology: sequence marks shifts, not uniform breakpoints.

01. Thematic chronology and institution evolution spine

Chronology visual. It keeps the topic thematic by separating institutional change from ruler-list memorisation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SCOPE, FRAMING AND CHRONOLOGY DISCIPLINE

START / CONCEPT: Scope, framing and chronology discipline

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Scope · framing · chronology discipline · changing, negotiated and regionally uneven rule · Topics 03-06 · Topic 08-09

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The best exam-safe frame is changing, negotiated and regionally uneven rule.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Therefore the package separates normative Persian vocabulary, chronicler claims, actual administration and later textbook generalisation before drawing conclusions.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: [DEBATE] Three distortions must be blocked at the beginning.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Topic 07 spans the Delhi Sultanate from its thirteenth-century consolidation to the Lodi transition, but it does so through institutions, revenue, markets, social hierarchy and historiography rather than by repeating ruler-biographies already owned by Topics 03-06.

SESSION 2 - STATE FORMATION: CONQUEST, COURT FORM AND INHERITED AGRARIAN STRUCTURES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: [DEBATE] The contrast is not between conquest and accommodation as mutually exclusive options.

Technical definition: Turkish conquest created fortified nodes, campaign corridors and cavalry households, but these alone did not produce a working state.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Turkish conquest created fortified nodes, campaign corridors and cavalry households, but these alone did not produce a working state.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- conquest
- court form
- inherited agrarian structures
- hierarchical military-fiscal network
- Turkish
- Topic

How to use them: Frame the answer through conquest; define court form, connect inherited agrarian structures with hierarchical military-fiscal network to explain the mechanism, and use Turkish for the decisive comparison or qualification.

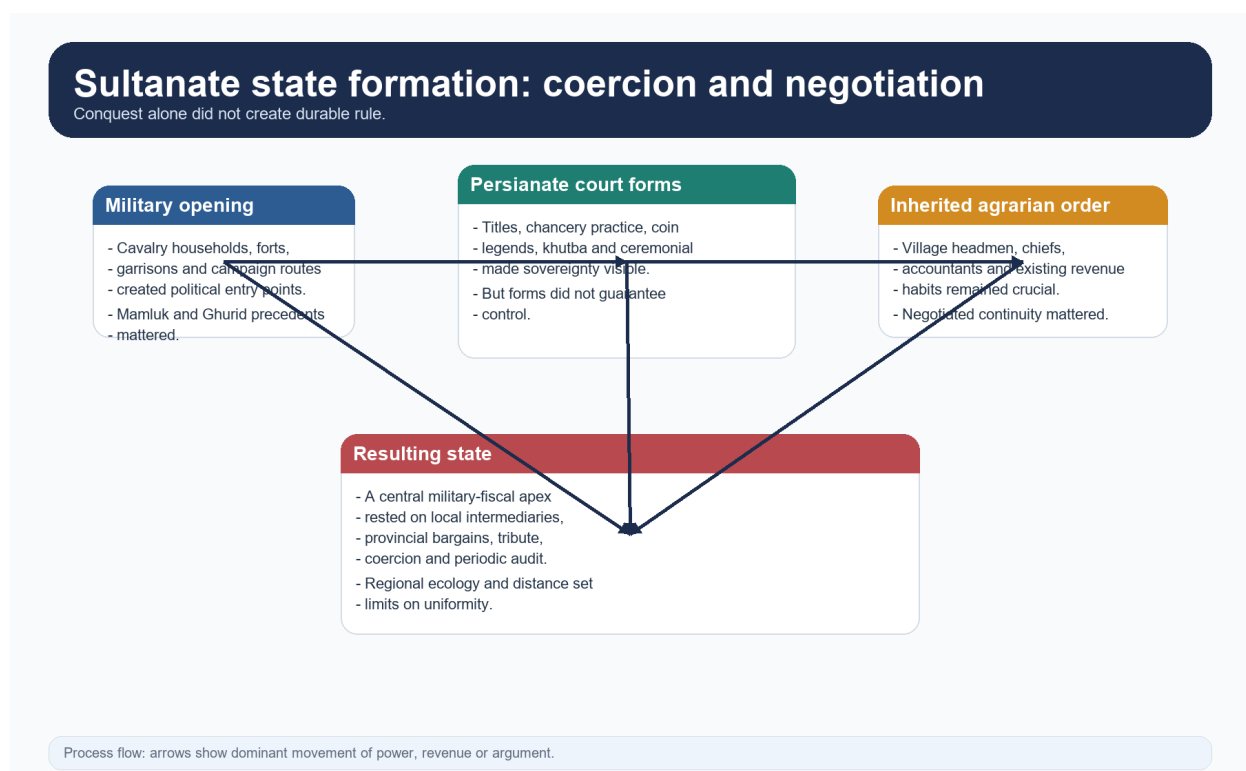
[FACT] Turkish conquest created fortified nodes, campaign corridors and cavalry households, but these alone did not produce a working state. Durable rule required revenue, communication, a persuasive court idiom and local intermediaries able to collect, report and police.

[FACT] The repository's Topic 01 and Topic 03 materials, read with the local OCR, show that the Turks who entered India were already Islamised and Persianised. They brought cavalry organisation, Persian chancery culture, elite military slavery and established idioms of sovereignty from West and Central Asia.

[FACT] At the same time, local agrarian structures were not rebuilt from zero. Village communities, headmen, chiefs, accountants and pre-existing revenue habits remained necessary for countryside control. Early Turkish rulers depended heavily on those structures.

[ANALYSIS] This is why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a **hierarchical military-fiscal network**. Coercion mattered, but so did negotiated continuity. The crown inserted itself above older structures, redirected surplus and promoted new elites without abolishing every earlier layer.

[DEBATE] The contrast is not between conquest and accommodation as mutually exclusive options. The actual historical process involved both: armed superiority at nodal points, then bargaining, delegation, audit and selective retention of local personnel.



State-formation visual. It shows why conquest, Persianate court practice and inherited agrarian society had to be combined.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - STATE FORMATION: CONQUEST, COURT FORM AND INHERITED AGRARIAN STRUCTURES

START / CONCEPT: State formation: conquest, court form and inherited agrarian structures
 |
 v
 EXACT TERMS: conquest · court form · inherited agrarian structures · hierarchical military-fiscal network · Turkish · Topic
 |
 v
 MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: At the same time, local agrarian structures were not rebuilt from zero.
 |
 v
 CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: [DEBATE] The contrast is not between conquest and accommodation as mutually exclusive options.
 |
 v
 UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the repository's Topic 01 and Topic 03 materials, read with the local OCR, show...
 |
 v
 ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Turkish conquest created fortified nodes, campaign corridors and cavalry households, but these alone did not produce a working state.

SESSION 3 - SULTAN, KINGSHIP, CALIPHATE AND POLITICAL EXPEDIENCY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The better contrast is between sharia-backed normative language and zawabit or political expediency.

Technical definition: Balban heightened awe and ceremonial distance; Alauddin argued that state necessity could not be reduced to juristic advice; Muhammad bin Tughlaq sought symbolic legitimacy while also issuing regulations; Firuz leaned further toward juristic approval without surrendering political calculation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The better contrast is between sharia-backed normative language and zawabit or political expediency.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Sultan
- kingship
- caliphate
- political expediency
- khutba
- sikka

How to use them: Frame the answer through Sultan; define kingship, connect caliphate with political expediency to explain the mechanism, and use khutba for the decisive comparison or qualification.

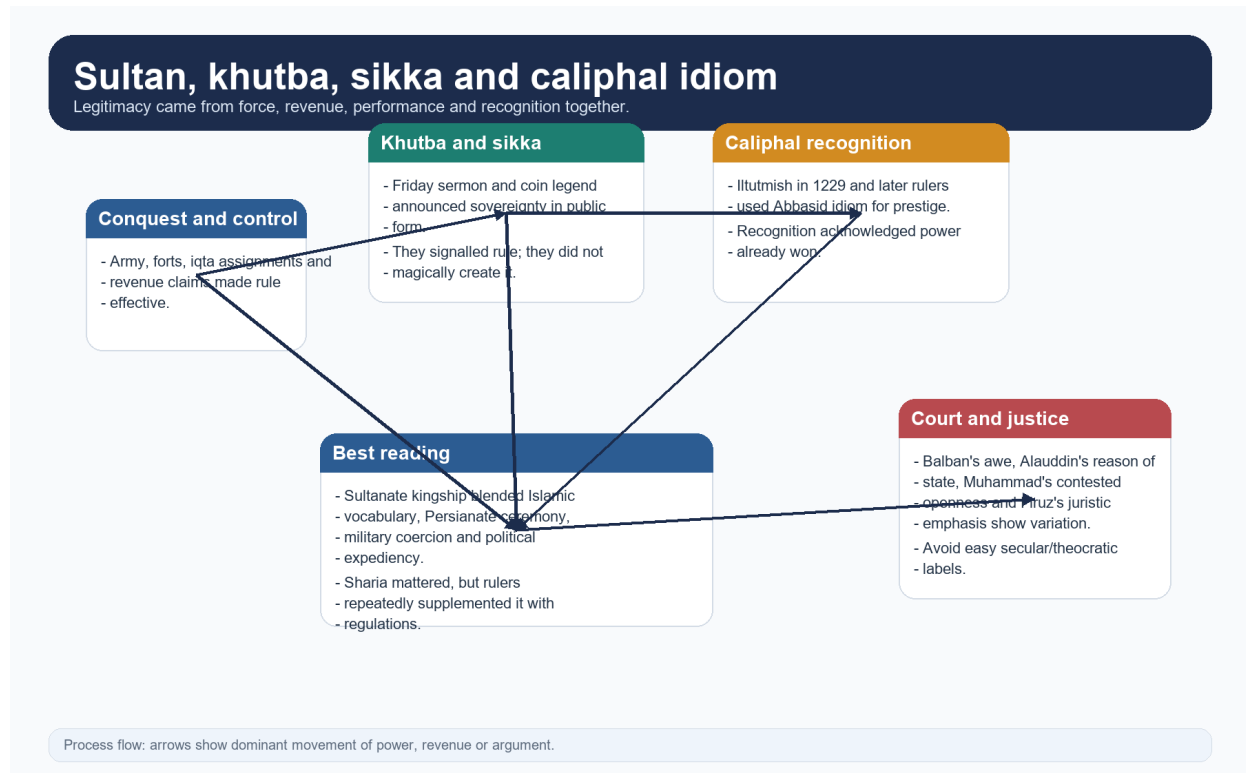
[FACT] The sultan stood at the apex of military command, office distribution, coinage and high justice. Sovereignty was signalled through **khutba**, **sikka**, titulature, court ceremonial and the power to hear petitions or overrule great officials.

[FACT] Iltutmish's caliphal recognition in 1229, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's use of Abbasid symbolism, and Firuz's later search for investiture all show that caliphal idiom mattered. Yet the evidence used across Topics 03 and 05 makes the key point unmistakable: such recognition enhanced status but did not create the army, the revenue base or the

countryside network of rule.

[ANALYSIS] Kingship under the Sultanate therefore mixed Islamic legitimacy, Persianate performance and reason of state. Balban heightened awe and ceremonial distance; Alauddin argued that state necessity could not be reduced to juristic advice; Muhammad bin Tughlaq sought symbolic legitimacy while also issuing regulations; Firuz leaned further toward juristic approval without surrendering political calculation.

[DEBATE] This is why modern labels such as 'secular' or 'theocratic' mislead. The better contrast is between **sharia-backed normative language** and **zawabit or political expediency**. Different rulers drew that balance differently, and the balance shifted with crisis.



04. Sultan - khutba - sikka - caliphate legitimacy chain

Legitimacy visual. It separates symbols of sovereignty from the material foundations of rule.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SULTAN, KINGSHIP, CALIPHATE AND POLITICAL EXPEDIENCY

START / CONCEPT: Sultan, kingship, caliphate and political expediency

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Sultan · kingship · caliphate · political expediency · khutba · sikka

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Sovereignty was signalled through khutba, sikka, titlature, court ceremonial and the power to hear petitions or overrule great officials.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Balban heightened awe and ceremonial distance; Alauddin argued that state necessity could not be reduced to juristic advice; Muhammad bin Tughlaq sought symbolic legitimacy while also issuing regulations; Firuz leaned further toward juristic approval without surrendering political calculation.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Yet the evidence used across Topics 03 and 05 makes the key point unmistakable: such recognition enhanced status but did not create the army, the revenue base or the countryside network of rule.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The better contrast is between sharia-backed normative language and zawabit or political expediency.

SESSION 4 - CENTRAL DEPARTMENTS AND THE PROBLEM OF PROJECTING ONE REIGN ACROSS ALL CENTURIES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The OCR itself shows caution around Diwan-i-Risalat; the weight of the wazir and the subordinates of finance shifted; some offices are best evidenced only under stronger or better-documented reigns.

Technical definition: Technically, Central departments and the problem of projecting one reign across all centuries is analysed by relating Central departments to wazir / Diwan-i-Wizarat, then testing the relationship through ariz / Diwan-i-Arz and Diwan-i-Insha.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The OCR itself shows caution around Diwan-i-Risalat; the weight of the wazir and the subordinates of finance shifted; some offices are best evidenced only under stronger or better-documented reigns.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Central departments
- wazir / Diwan-i-Wizarat
- ariz / Diwan-i-Arz
- Diwan-i-Insha
- Diwan-i-Risalat
- sadr

How to use them: Frame the answer through Central departments; define wazir / Diwan-i-Wizarat, connect ariz / Diwan-i-Arz with Diwan-i-Insha to explain the mechanism, and use Diwan-i-Risalat for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The local OCR and Topic 03 package together confirm the main institutional cluster: **wazir / Diwan-i-Wizarat** for finance and oversight, **ariz / Diwan-i-Arz** for muster and equipment, **Diwan-i-Insha** for correspondence, and **Diwan-i-Risalat** in Satish Chandra's reconstruction for religious grants and pious matters.

[FACT] Other key offices included the **sadr**, chief **qazi**, **muhtasib**, **barid**, **wakil-i-dar**, **amir hajib**, royal stores or **karkhanas**, public works, and under Firuz a separate department for slaves.

[LIMIT] Topic 07 must resist the temptation to draw one permanent chart. The OCR itself shows caution around Diwan-i-Risalat; the weight of the wazir and the subordinates of finance shifted; some offices are best evidenced only under stronger or better-documented reigns.

[ANALYSIS] Institutional differentiation was real, and this matters against caricatures of pure personal rule. But differentiation did not mean a modern file-driven bureaucracy. The crown relied on people whose actual reach depended on the ruler's strength, military follow-through and local mediation.

Central departments and offices: function with period caveat

Do not project one reign's diagram across three centuries.

Office	Core function	Why caution matters
Wazir / Diwan-i-Wizarat	Finance, income, expenditure, oversight of accounts and provincial claims	Weight and subordinates changed by reign; strong sultans overruled great wazirs.
Ariz / Diwan-i-Ariz	Muster, horses, equipment, descriptive rolls and payment supervision	Ariz was not commander-in-chief; that remained the sultan.
Diwan-i-Insha	State correspondence, orders, diplomatic letters and chancery language	Document survival is uneven and formulaic.
Diwan-i-Risalat	Often linked to religious grants and pious endowments in this source base	Other reconstructions give it diplomatic or petitionary roles in some reigns.
Sadr, chief qazi, muhtasib, barid	Religious grants, justice, public morals, intelligence and reporting	Best evidenced at the capital and stronger centres; reach varied.
Wakil-i-dar, amir hajib, karkhanas	Court household, ceremonial order, stores, workshops and construction	Especially visible in Firuz's reign and major capitals.

Reading rule

Read departments as evolving clusters of function, not a frozen

Comparisons ~~organogram~~ category labels as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

03. Central departments comparison with period caveat

Institution matrix. The point is function with chronology caution, not bureaucratic timelessness.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CENTRAL DEPARTMENTS AND THE PROBLEM OF PROJECTING ONE REIGN ACROSS ALL CENTURIES

START / CONCEPT: Central departments and the problem of projecting one reign across all centuries

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Central departments · wazir / Diwan-i-Wizarat · ariz / Diwan-i-Ariz · Diwan-i-Insha · Diwan-i-Risalat · sadr

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The crown relied on people whose actual reach depended on the ruler's strength, military follow-through and local mediation.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Topic 07 must resist the temptation to draw one permanent chart.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: and this matters against caricatures of pure personal rule.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The OCR itself shows caution around Diwan-i-Risalat; the weight of the wazir and the subordinates of finance shifted; some offices are best evidenced only under stronger or better-documented reigns.

SESSION 5 - NOBILITY AND ELITE COMPOSITION: WIDER RECRUITMENT, SHARPER FACTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: His rage is evidence for elite hierarchy as much as for the appointments themselves.

Technical definition: The composition widened over time and varied by ruler.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

[DEBATE] The safest way to write this is not 'racial conflict' or 'class conflict' alone, but status-stratified elite competition in which ethnicity, household rank, old service, new service and local landed connections all mattered.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Nobility
- elite composition
- wider recruitment
- sharper faction
- status-stratified elite competition
- The Sultanate

How to use them: Frame the answer through Nobility; define elite composition, connect wider recruitment with sharper faction to explain the mechanism, and use status-stratified elite competition for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The Sultanate elite included Turks, military slaves, Tajiks/Persians, Khaljis, Afghans, Indian Muslims, converts, ulema, clerks, local chiefs and Hindu managers or accountants. The composition widened over time and varied by ruler.

[FACT] The Part I OCR shows that many chroniclers turned social prejudice into political theory. Barani, for example, openly distrusted the promotion of people of humble occupational background, converts and low-born officials. His rage is evidence for elite hierarchy as much as for the appointments themselves.

[ANALYSIS] Political consequence followed social composition. Narrower Mamluk-Turkish dominance gave strong early cohesion but also exclusion; Khalji and Tughlaq widening increased talent and reach but aggravated faction; Lodi Afghan politics carried strong expectations of consultation and honour, complicating central monarchy.

[DEBATE] The safest way to write this is not 'racial conflict' or 'class conflict' alone, but **status-stratified elite competition** in which ethnicity, household rank, old service, new service and local landed connections all mattered.

Nobility and ruling elite composition

The court was never a single ethnic bloc for long.

Group	What it contributed	Built-in tension
Turks and military slaves	Cavalry command, household loyalty, early prestige and frontier defence	High-born exclusivism and factional contest.
Tajiks / Persians / immigrants	Administrative literacy, chancery culture, finance and juristic expertise	Could be resented as outsiders or literati.
Khaljis, Afghans and new men	Broader recruitment, military manpower, fresh provincial ties	Widened opportunity but unsettled old monopoly.
Indian Muslims and converts	Lower administration, service, intelligence and some high office under expansive rulers	Barani-type prejudice treated many as low-born.
Hindu chiefs and accountants	Local knowledge, revenue collection, landed strength and practical governance	Cooperation and conflict coexisted.
Ulema and pious grantees	Legitimizing language, legal expertise, institutional memory	Could not be allowed to dictate every policy without shrinking the state.

Reading rule

Source bias is strong: many chroniclers turned status

prejudice into political theory as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

05. Nobility composition and faction matrix

Elite-composition visual. It shows why widening the ruling class changed both state capacity and political friction.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - NOBILITY AND ELITE COMPOSITION: WIDER RECRUITMENT, SHARPER FACTION

START / CONCEPT: Nobility and elite composition: wider recruitment, sharper faction

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Nobility · elite composition · wider recruitment · sharper faction · status-stratified elite competition · The Sultanate

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Sultanate elite included Turks, military slaves, Tajiks/Persians, Khaljis, Afghans, Indian Muslims, converts, ulema, clerks, local chiefs and Hindu managers or accountants.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: His rage is evidence for elite hierarchy as much as for the appointments themselves.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the composition widened over time and varied by ruler.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: [DEBATE] The safest way to write this is not 'racial conflict' or 'class conflict' alone, but status-stratified elite competition in which ethnicity, household rank, old service, new service and local landed connections all mattered.

SESSION 6 - BANDAGAN AND MILITARY SLAVERY: ELITE TRAINING, NOT MASS CHATTEL EQUIVALENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Their careers show why military slavery cannot be read only as degradation; it was also an elite recruitment technology.

Technical definition: Military slavery should not erase other forms of slavery.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Their careers show why military slavery cannot be read only as degradation; it was also an elite recruitment technology.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Bandagan
- military slavery
- elite training
- not mass chattel equivalence
- Topic
- Aibak

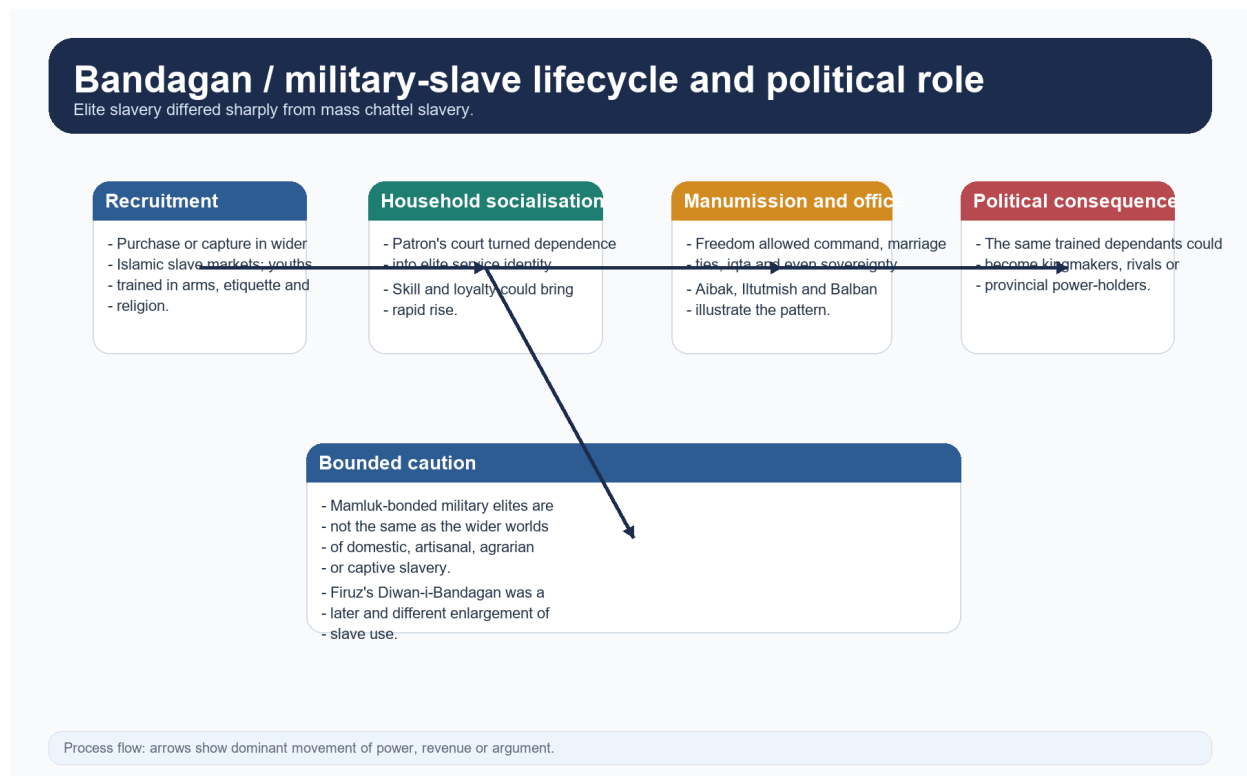
How to use them: Frame the answer through Bandagan; define military slavery, connect elite training with not mass chattel equivalence to explain the mechanism, and use Topic for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Topic 03 establishes the core distinction: *mamluk* or military-household slavery referred to selected dependants trained in warfare, service, etiquette and loyalty. Manumission allowed them to hold office, marriage alliances and even sovereignty.

[FACT] Aibak, Iltutmish and Balban all emerged from such service worlds. Their careers show why military slavery cannot be read only as degradation; it was also an elite recruitment technology.

[ANALYSIS] Yet the institution generated its own instability. The same household training that produced loyal commanders could also produce rivals once those men accumulated troops, assignments and prestige. Topic 06 shows the later edge of this problem when Firuz's vast slave establishment became politically dangerous after his death.

[LIMIT] Military slavery should not erase other forms of slavery. Domestic, artisanal, war-captive and palace slavery remained part of medieval society, usually without the path to power visible in the elite bandagan pattern.



06. Bandagan lifecycle and political role

Bandagan visual. It distinguishes recruitment, training, manumission and later political risk.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - BANDAGAN AND MILITARY SLAVERY: ELITE TRAINING, NOT MASS CHATTEL EQUIVALENCE

START / CONCEPT: Bandagan and military slavery: elite training, not mass chattel equivalence

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Bandagan · military slavery · elite training · not mass chattel equivalence · Topic · Aibak

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The same household training that produced loyal commanders could also produce rivals once those men accumulated troops, assignments and prestige.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Military slavery should not erase other forms of slavery.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: topic 03 establishes the core distinction.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Their careers show why military slavery cannot be read only as degradation; it was also an elite recruitment technology.

SESSION 7 - IQTA AS ASSIGNMENT, NOT SIMPLE PROPERTY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: In principle is not the same as in practice.

Technical definition: Both the concise and advanced OCRs show the same basic logic: the crown claimed superior fiscal right; the muqti met expenditure and service obligations; surplus and accounts were, in principle, answerable to the centre; transfer or recall prevented permanent rooting when the state was strong.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Therefore the iqta must be explained as a moving field of negotiation, not as a fixed legal machine.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Iqta as assignment
- not simple property
- Both
- OCRs
- In principle
- In

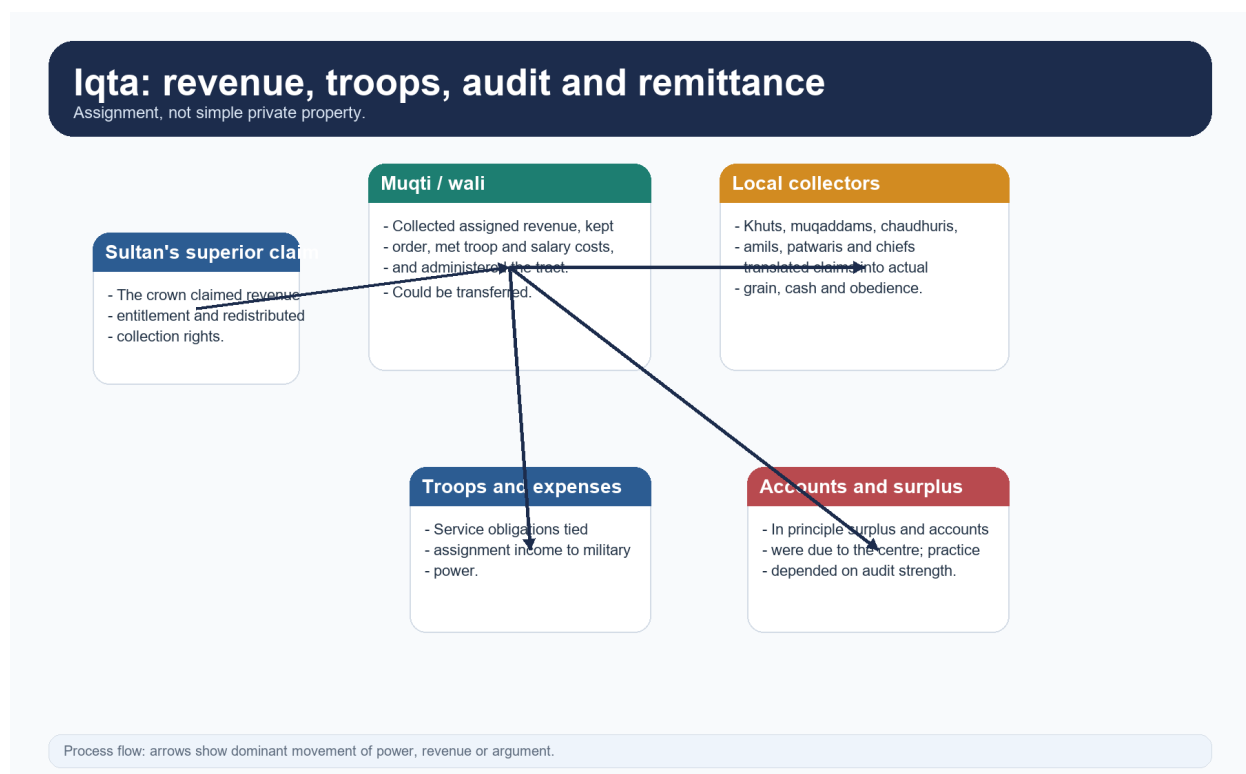
How to use them: Frame the answer through Iqta as assignment; define not simple property, connect Both with OCRs to explain the mechanism, and use In principle for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The iqta carried a right to realise revenue and often to maintain order and troops in a tract. The muqti or wali was not the absolute owner of soil and population.

[FACT] Both the concise and advanced OCRs show the same basic logic: the crown claimed superior fiscal right; the muqti met expenditure and service obligations; surplus and accounts were, in principle, answerable to the centre; transfer or recall prevented permanent rooting when the state was strong.

[ANALYSIS] Iqta linked agrarian surplus to military capacity. It allowed the Sultanate to support cavalry and provincial administration without paying everything from a single treasury. This made it a central device of state formation.

[LIMIT] In principle is not the same as in practice. Distance, armed followings, provincial autonomy and weak rulers reduced the effectiveness of transfer and audit. Therefore the iqta must be explained as a moving field of negotiation, not as a fixed legal machine.



07. Iqta revenue-troop-audit-remittance flow

Iqta flow visual. It puts service, expenditure, local mediation and central claim into one chain.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - IQTA AS ASSIGNMENT, NOT SIMPLE PROPERTY

START / CONCEPT: Iqta as assignment, not simple property

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Iqta as assignment · not simple property · Both · OCRs · In principle · In

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Both the concise and advanced OCRs show the same basic logic: the crown claimed superior fiscal right; the muqti met expenditure and service obligations; surplus and accounts were, in principle, answerable to the centre; transfer or recall prevented permanent rooting when the state was strong.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The muqti or wali was not the absolute owner of soil and population.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: In principle is not the same as in practice.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Therefore the iqta must be explained as a moving field of negotiation, not as a fixed legal machine.

SESSION 8 - IQTA ACROSS DYNASTIES: TIGHTENING, OVERREACH AND HEREDITARY DRIFT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: A mature answer explains iqta as one institution whose political meaning changed with central strength.

Technical definition: [DEBATE] The safest comparison with Mughal jagir is through tenure, accountability and service obligation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

A mature answer explains iqta as one institution whose political meaning changed with central strength.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **iqta across dynasties**
- **tightening**
- **overreach**
- **hereditary drift**
- **[DEBATE] The safest comparison with Mughal jagir**
- **DEBATE**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Iqta across dynasties; define tightening, connect overreach with hereditary drift to explain the mechanism, and use [DEBATE] The safest comparison with Mughal jagir for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Under the Mamluks, iqta helped consolidation. Under Alauddin, closer supervision, khalisa expansion and direct revenue pressure in the core sharpened control. Under Muhammad bin Tughlaq, large empire and fiscal experimentation strained the system. Under Firuz, heredity and softer audit localised claims.

[ANALYSIS] This sequence matters more than any static definition. A mature answer explains iqta as one institution whose political meaning changed with central strength. The same assignment logic could support centralisation in one phase and oligarchic localisation in another.

[DEBATE] The safest comparison with Mughal *jagir* is through tenure, accountability and service obligation. The safest comparison with European feudalism is to say that the analogy is limited: a transferable state assignment tied to fiscal claim is not the same thing as an inherited proprietary fief.

[LIMIT] Phrases such as 'feudalisation' may be used only if unpacked carefully. On their own they often hide more than they explain.

Iqta evolution across dynasties

Continuity existed, but so did sharp changes in supervision and heredity.

Phase	What changed	Exam-safe caution
Mamluk	Iqta helped consolidation; transfer and recall limited local rooting; procedures were still evolving.	Do not project later paperwork backward in full detail.
Khalji	Khalisa expansion, heavy doab extraction and closer army checks tightened fiscal control.	Alauddin did not abolish intermediaries altogether.
Muhammad bin Tughlaq	Cash demands, widened recruitment and ambitious expansion strained the system.	Not every experiment lasted or worked.
Firuz Tughlaq	Heredity in office and assignment softer audit and village-based military payment lowered discipline.	Safer phrase: localisation of claims, not automatic feudal equivalence.
Sayyid-Lodi	Negotiated sovereignty and Afghan politics pulled assignment power toward regional bargaining.	Do not confuse this with complete state disappearance.

Reading rule

Compare with Mughal jagir only through tenure, service and accountability and by calling them identical.

Comparisons are analytical, not timeless absolutes.

08. Iqta evolution across dynasties

Evolution visual. It shows why one sentence on iqta is never enough for all Sultanate centuries.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - IQTA ACROSS DYNASTIES: TIGHTENING, OVERREACH AND HEREDITARY DRIFT

START / CONCEPT: Iqta across dynasties: tightening, overreach and hereditary drift

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Iqta across dynasties • tightening • overreach • hereditary drift • [DEBATE] The safest comparison with Mughal jagir • DEBATE

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: [DEBATE] The safest comparison with Mughal jagir is through tenure, accountability and service obligation.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The safest comparison with European feudalism is to say that the analogy is limited: a transferable state assignment tied to fiscal claim is not the same thing as an inherited proprietary fief.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the same assignment logic could support centralisation in one phase and oligarchic localisation in...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: A mature answer explains iqta as one institution whose political meaning changed with central strength.

SESSION 9 - PROVINCIAL AND LOCAL ADMINISTRATION: HIERARCHY BELOW THE PROVINCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The hierarchy below the province was where negotiated sovereignty became real.

Technical definition: We should not turn the local layer into complete village autonomy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The hierarchy below the province was where negotiated sovereignty became real.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Provincial
- local administration
- hierarchy below the province
- shiqs
- parganas
- sadis

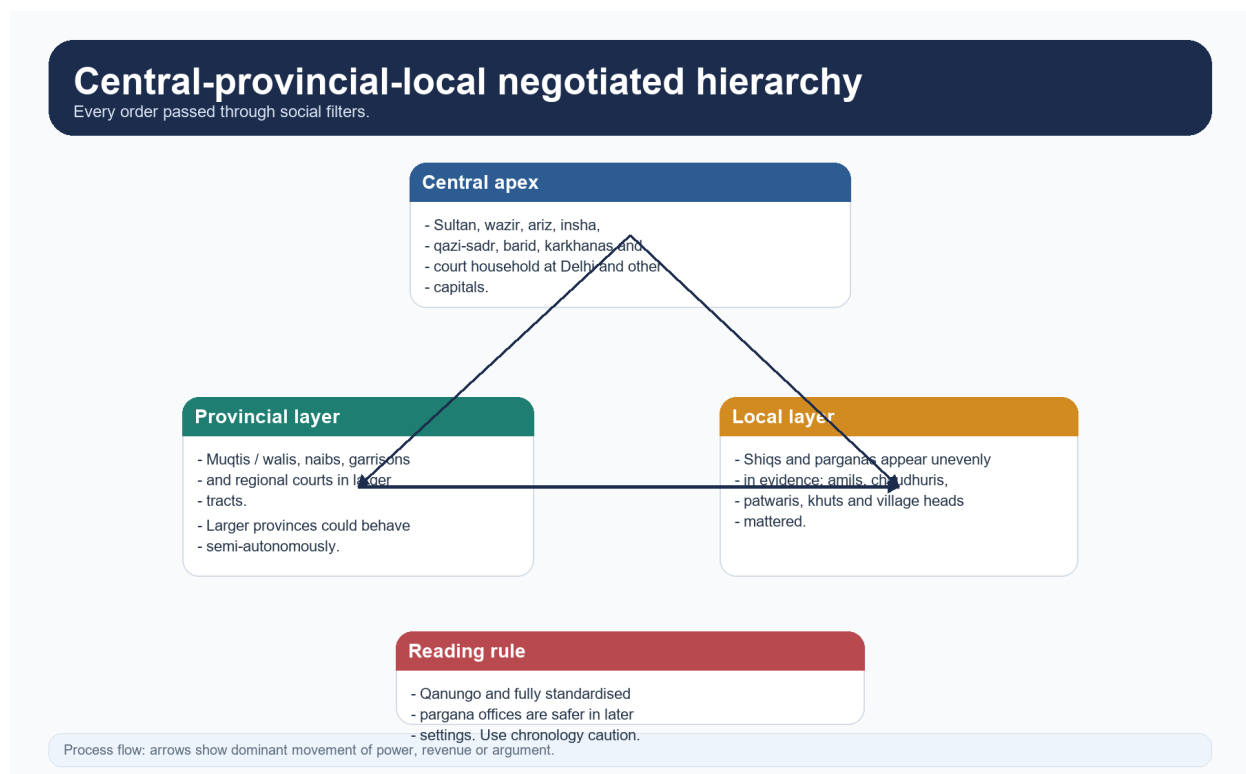
How to use them: Frame the answer through Provincial; define local administration, connect hierarchy below the province with shiqs to explain the mechanism, and use parganas for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The advanced OCR notes provinces under larger rulers and confirms that below them one hears of **shiqs**, **parganas**, **sadis** and **chaurasis**, though not with equal clarity for all periods. The pargana was associated with the **amil**, while village society revolved around the **khut**, **muqaddam** and **patwari**.

[FACT] Topic 07's own repaired core also cautions that the term **zamindar** appears more clearly by the early fourteenth century and broadens later. Likewise, the historian must be careful with later familiar offices such as **qanungo**.

[ANALYSIS] The hierarchy below the province was where negotiated sovereignty became real. The local holder knew the fields, the cattle, the people and the conditions of transport. Therefore no central revenue order could work without this stratum.

[LIMIT] We should not turn the local layer into complete village autonomy. Nor should we turn it into a standardised district bureaucracy identical from Lahore to Mabbar. The evidence supports something in between.



09. Central-provincial-local negotiated hierarchy

Hierarchy visual. It emphasises mediation, not a clean top-down administrative pipe.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PROVINCIAL AND LOCAL ADMINISTRATION: HIERARCHY BELOW THE PROVINCE

START / CONCEPT: Provincial and local administration: hierarchy below the province

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Provincial · local administration · hierarchy below the province · shiqs · parganas · sadis

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: We should not turn the local layer into complete village autonomy.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The pargana was associated with the amil, while village society revolved around the khut, muqaddam and patwari.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: therefore no central revenue order could work without this stratum.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The hierarchy below the province was where negotiated sovereignty became real.

SESSION 10 - REVENUE SYSTEM: LEGAL CATEGORIES AND ACTUAL FISCAL PRACTICE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: [DEBATE] Therefore the correct method is to use legal categories as starting points, then ask what was actually being taken, from whom, through which intermediary and for which political purpose.

Technical definition: The local OCR is especially useful on the gap between label and practice.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Alauddin's half-share demand in the upper doab, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's standard-yield cash incidence and Firuz's share-based reassessment show that actual revenue practice turned on political aim, local coercive ability and environmental conditions far more than on one legal formula.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Revenue system
- legal categories
- actual fiscal practice
- The local OCR
- OCR
- Early

How to use them: Frame the answer through Revenue system; define legal categories, connect actual fiscal practice with The local OCR to explain the mechanism, and use OCR for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Sultanate revenue language included *kharaj*, *ushr*, *zakat*, *jizya*, *khams*, transit dues and cesses such as *ghari*, *charai* and later irrigation dues such as *haqq-i-sharb*.

[FACT] The local OCR is especially useful on the gap between label and practice. Early on, *jizya* was often difficult to distinguish from land demand. Firuz later insisted on making it a separate tax and extended it to Brahmans, using juristic language to present the order as purified.

[ANALYSIS] Alauddin's half-share demand in the upper doab, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's standard-yield cash incidence and Firuz's share-based reassessment show that actual revenue practice turned on political aim, local coercive ability and environmental conditions far more than on one legal formula.

[DEBATE] Therefore the correct method is to use legal categories as starting points, then ask what was actually being taken, from whom, through which intermediary and for which political purpose.

Revenue categories: legal language versus fiscal practice

The category grid never exhausted reality on the ground.

Category	Formal meaning	Practice caution
Kharaj	Land revenue on conquered/agricultural land in juristic vocabulary.	In India it merged with practical crop and cash demand.
Ushr	Tithe-like levy associated with Muslim-held or specially classified land.	Much less visible than kharaj in Sultanate practice.
Zakat	Religious levy on Muslims under Islamic law.	Not the main key to understanding Sultanate agrarian finance.
Jizya	Poll tax on protected non-Muslims.	Often merged in practice with land demand until Firuz separated it more clearly.
Khams	Fifth of war booty in legal theory.	Campaign realities and distribution could vary.
Customs and cesses	Transit dues, market charges, ghari, charai and irrigation dues such as haqq-i-sharb.	A ruler could abolish some and multiply others; not one static list.

Reading rule

For UPSC, always separate the legal label from actual fiscal

extraction. Treat category labels as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

10. Revenue categories legal-vs-practice matrix

Fiscal matrix. It separates juristic label from lived extraction, which is the heart of Topic 07.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - REVENUE SYSTEM: LEGAL CATEGORIES AND ACTUAL FISCAL PRACTICE

START / CONCEPT: Revenue system: legal categories and actual fiscal practice

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Revenue system • legal categories • actual fiscal practice • The local OCR • OCR •

Early

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: [DEBATE] Therefore the correct method is to use legal categories as starting points, then ask what was actually being taken, from whom, through which intermediary and for which political purpose.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The local OCR is especially useful on the gap between label and practice.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Early on, jizya was often difficult to distinguish from land demand.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Alauddin's half-share demand in the upper doab, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's standard-yield cash incidence and Firuz's share-based reassessment show that actual revenue practice turned on political aim, local coercive ability and environmental conditions far more than on one legal formula.

SESSION 11 - ARMY AND LOGISTICS: CAVALRY, ELEPHANTS, BRANDING AND ROUTE SECURITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Army and logistics: cavalry, elephants, branding and route security comprises Army, logistics and cavalry as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Army and logistics: cavalry, elephants, branding and route security is analysed by relating Army to logistics, then testing the relationship through cavalry and elephants.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Army and logistics: cavalry, elephants, branding and route security comprises Army, logistics and cavalry as its core connected dimensions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Army
- logistics
- cavalry
- elephants
- branding
- route security

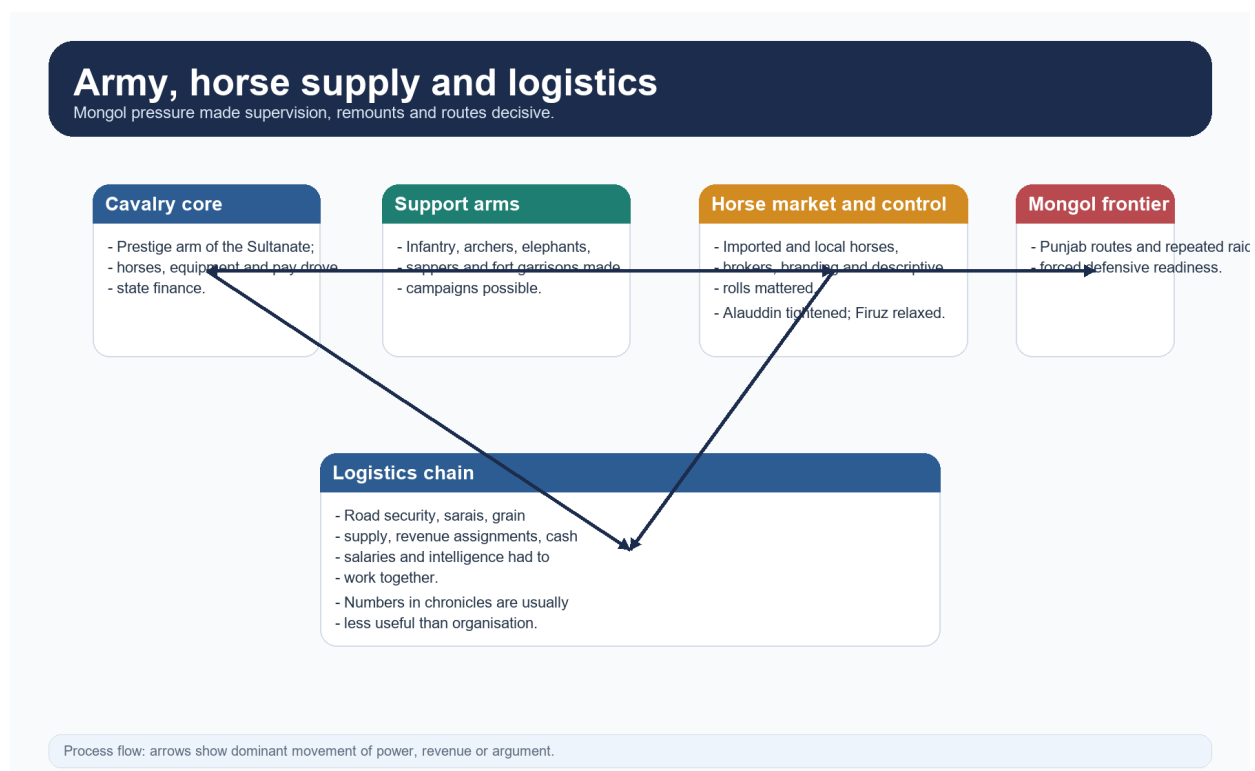
How to use them: Frame the answer through Army; define logistics, connect cavalry with elephants to explain the mechanism, and use branding for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The Sultanate army centred on cavalry, but also used infantry, archers, elephants, miners, sappers, fort garrisons and transport labour. The concise OCR directly notes the sappers and miners attached to armies.

[FACT] Horses were crucial and expensive. Their supply depended on inland trade, import channels and monitoring. Alauddin's **dagh** and **chehra** tightened that system; Firuz's regime relaxed it.

[ANALYSIS] Military history here is really fiscal history plus transport history. A cavalry state needed grain, remounts, road security, garrisons, reliable intelligence and money or assignments capable of turning field command into durable obedience.

[LIMIT] Chronicle troop totals are among the least safe materials in the archive. For UPSC, organisation, inspection, pay form and logistical chains are much stronger than raw numbers.



11. Army, logistics and horse-supply system

Army-system visual. It shows why horse control, grain and intelligence belong in the same answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ARMY AND LOGISTICS: CAVALRY, ELEPHANTS, BRANDING AND ROUTE SECURITY

START / CONCEPT: Army and logistics: cavalry, elephants, branding and route security

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Army · logistics · cavalry · elephants · branding · route security

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Chronicle troop totals are among the least safe materials in the archive.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: For UPSC, organisation, inspection, pay form and logistical chains are much stronger than raw numbers.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: military history here is really fiscal history plus transport history.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Army and logistics: cavalry, elephants, branding and route security comprises Army, logistics and cavalry as its core connected dimensions.

SESSION 12 - POLICE, MARKET OVERSIGHT AND JUDICIAL PLURALITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Judicial plurality was built into the structure.

Technical definition: The muhtasib checked weights, measures and public conduct in terms defined by Muslim moral law.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Judicial plurality was built into the structure.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Police
- market oversight
- judicial plurality
- kotwal
- muhtasib
- qazi

How to use them: Frame the answer through Police; define market oversight, connect judicial plurality with kotwal to explain the mechanism, and use muhtasib for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The **kotwal** maintained urban order, regulated entry, watched markets and oversaw security. The **muhtasib** checked weights, measures and public conduct in terms defined by Muslim moral law. The **qazi** and **mufti** handled formal legal business for Muslims.

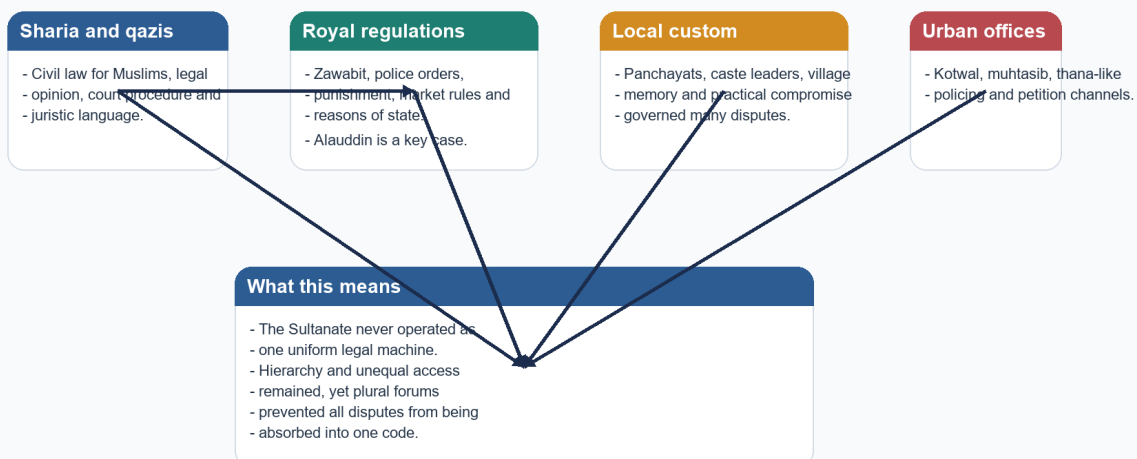
[FACT] The same OCR also states that Hindus were often governed by their own laws through panchayats in villages and caste-community authorities in towns. Criminal justice, meanwhile, could rest on royal regulation.

[ANALYSIS] Judicial plurality was built into the structure. Sharia mattered, but it was not the only operating norm. This is especially important when answering questions on law, society or religious policy.

[LIMIT] Delhi gives the richest evidence. It is unsafe to describe every town of the Sultanate as if it had identical policing density or documentary depth.

Law and judicial pluralism

Multiple normative orders operated together.



Process flow: arrows show dominant movement of power, revenue or argument.

12. Law and judicial pluralism network

Judicial-pluralism visual. It links qazi courts, royal regulation, local custom and urban offices.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - POLICE, MARKET OVERSIGHT AND JUDICIAL PLURALITY

START / CONCEPT: Police, market oversight and judicial plurality

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Police · market oversight · judicial plurality · kotwal · muhtasib · qazi

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The muhtasib checked weights, measures and public conduct in terms defined by Muslim moral law.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Sharia mattered, but it was not the only operating norm.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the same OCR also states that Hindus were often governed by their own laws...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Judicial plurality was built into the structure.

SESSION 13 - AGRARIAN BASE: CROPS, IRRIGATION, WELLS, CANALS AND ENVIRONMENTAL RISK

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Agrarian base: crops, irrigation, wells, canals and environmental risk comprises Agrarian base, crops and irrigation as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Agrarian history should therefore be read through ecology as well as administration.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Topic 07 therefore uses crop range, irrigation form, and regional caution instead of invented output statistics.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Agrarian base

- crops
- irrigation
- wells
- canals
- environmental risk

How to use them: Frame the answer through Agrarian base; define crops, connect irrigation with wells to explain the mechanism, and use canals for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The source base repeatedly mentions rice, sugarcane, wheat, oilseeds, sesame, indigo and cotton. Rain-fed agriculture remained dominant, but wells, bunds, tanks and local water control were significant.

[FACT] The concise and advanced OCR both highlight Firuz's canals, especially in the Haryana-Hisar zone. They represented a major state intervention, but not a transformation of every agrarian landscape in India.

[ANALYSIS] Agrarian history should therefore be read through ecology as well as administration. Forest cover, cattle wealth, recurrent famine, war and transport difficulty all shaped what the state could actually collect.

[LIMIT] The evidence does not support neat production totals. Topic 07 therefore uses crop range, irrigation form, and regional caution instead of invented output statistics.

Agrarian base: irrigation, crops and environmental limits

No exact production statistics are secure enough for rote use.

Dimension	Evidence-safe statement	Qualification
Crops	Rice, sugarcane, wheat, oilseeds, sesame, indigo and cotton are repeatedly attested.	Regional patterns varied strongly.
Water control	Rain-fed farming dominated, but wells, bunds, tanks and local irrigation were important; Firuz built canals.	Canals benefited core zones more than the whole empire.
Gardens and orchards	Elites invested in orchards and fruit improvement around towns and courts.	This aided prestige and urban supply more than mass welfare.
Environment	Famines, warfare, forest cover and transport bottlenecks shaped production and security.	Do not infer steady linear growth.
Peasant differentiation	Owner-cultivators, share-croppers, artisans, labourers and headmen did not face the system equally.	Sources are stronger on elites than on ordinary cultivators.

Reading rule

Agrarian history is about ecology plus institutions plus coercion -

Comparison never about state orders alone, analytical, not timeless absolutes.

14. Irrigation, crop and environment matrix

Agrarian matrix. It keeps crops, water control and environmental limits in one analytical frame.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - AGRARIAN BASE: CROPS, IRRIGATION, WELLS, CANALS AND ENVIRONMENTAL RISK

START / CONCEPT: Agrarian base: crops, irrigation, wells, canals and environmental risk
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Agrarian base · crops · irrigation · wells · canals · environmental risk
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Agrarian history should therefore be read through ecology as well as administration.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Rain-fed agriculture remained dominant, but wells, bunds, tanks and local water control were significant.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The evidence does not support neat production totals.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Topic 07 therefore uses crop range, irrigation form, and regional caution instead of invented output statistics.

SESSION 14 - SURPLUS TRANSFER, PEASANT BURDEN AND THE MILITARY-FISCAL STATE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Surplus transfer, peasant burden and the military-fiscal state comprises Surplus transfer, peasant burden and the military-fiscal state as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Surplus transfer, peasant burden and the military-fiscal state is analysed by relating Surplus transfer to peasant burden, then testing the relationship through the military-fiscal state and Owner-cultivators.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

This is the core of the military-fiscal interpretation.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Surplus transfer**
- **peasant burden**
- **the military-fiscal state**
- **Owner-cultivators**
- **OCR**
- **Firuz's**

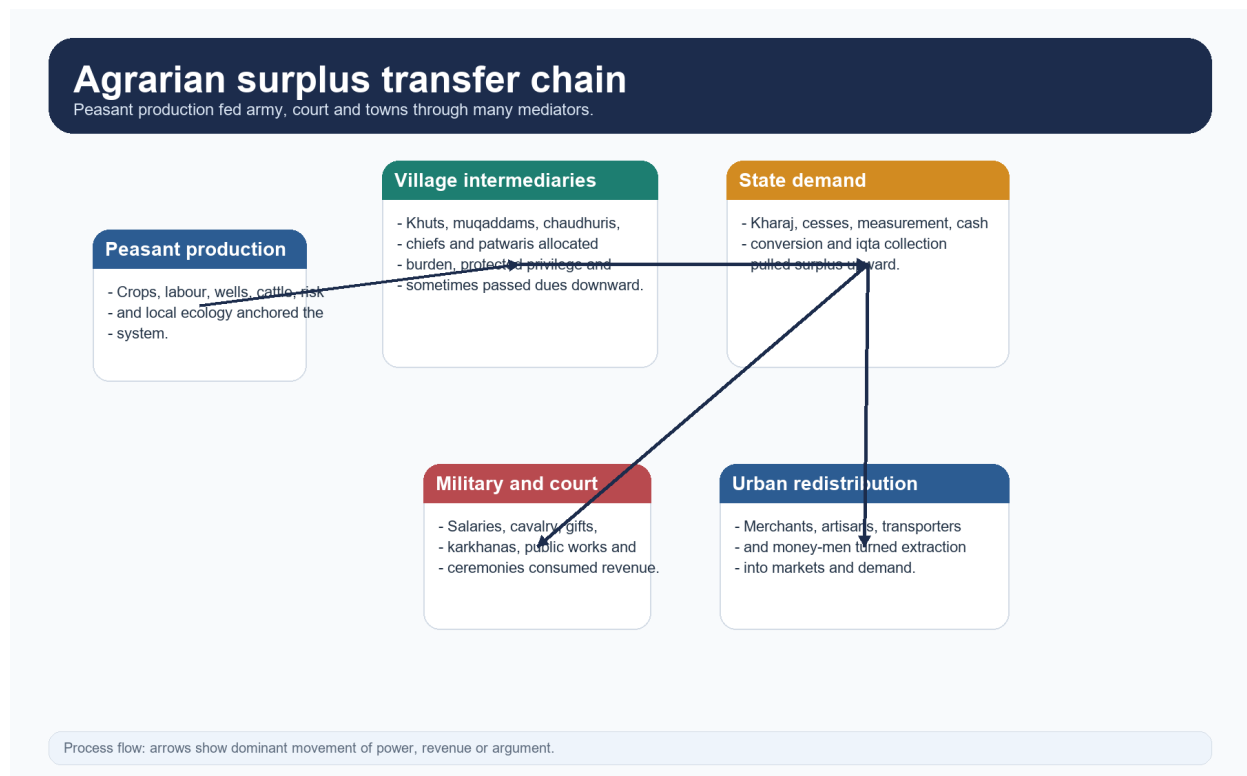
How to use them: Frame the answer through Surplus transfer; define peasant burden, connect the military-fiscal state with Owner-cultivators to explain the mechanism, and use OCR for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The overwhelming mass of cultivators worked close to subsistence, but not all rural groups stood alike. Owner-cultivators, prosperous village heads, chiefs and concessions for privileged intermediaries created strong internal differentiation.

[FACT] The concise OCR notes the prosperity of khuts and muqaddams in some areas before Alauddin cut their privileges. The advanced OCR explains that Firuz's irrigation success also channelled gain strongly toward holders of assignments and privileged rural groups.

[ANALYSIS] This is the core of the military-fiscal interpretation. The state did not merely tax an undifferentiated peasantry. It pushed demand through a hierarchy in which local elites could protect themselves, shift burden downward or bargain with the centre.

[DEBATE] Historiography divides between growth and extraction less sharply than textbooks often suggest. Urban and commercial vitality was real; so was hard agrarian transfer. The strongest answer combines both.



13. Agrarian surplus-transfer chain

Surplus-chain visual. It shows how peasant production, intermediaries and state demand fed court and town life.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SURPLUS TRANSFER, PEASANT BURDEN AND THE MILITARY-FISCAL STATE

START / CONCEPT: Surplus transfer, peasant burden and the military-fiscal state

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Surplus transfer · peasant burden · the military-fiscal state · Owner-cultivators ·
OCR · Firuz's

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: It pushed demand through a hierarchy in which local elites could protect themselves, shift burden downward or bargain with the centre.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Urban and commercial vitality was real; so was hard agrarian transfer.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the advanced OCR explains that Firuz's irrigation success also channelled gain strongly toward holders...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: This is the core of the military-fiscal interpretation.

SESSION 15 - CURRENCY, TRUST AND UNEVEN MONETISATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Currency, trust and uneven monetisation comprises Currency, trust and uneven monetisation as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Currency, trust and uneven monetisation is analysed by relating Currency to trust, then testing the relationship through uneven monetisation and tanka.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Token currency is a bounded example, not the whole monetary history of the Sultanate.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Currency
- trust
- uneven monetisation
- tanka
- jital
- Iltutmish's

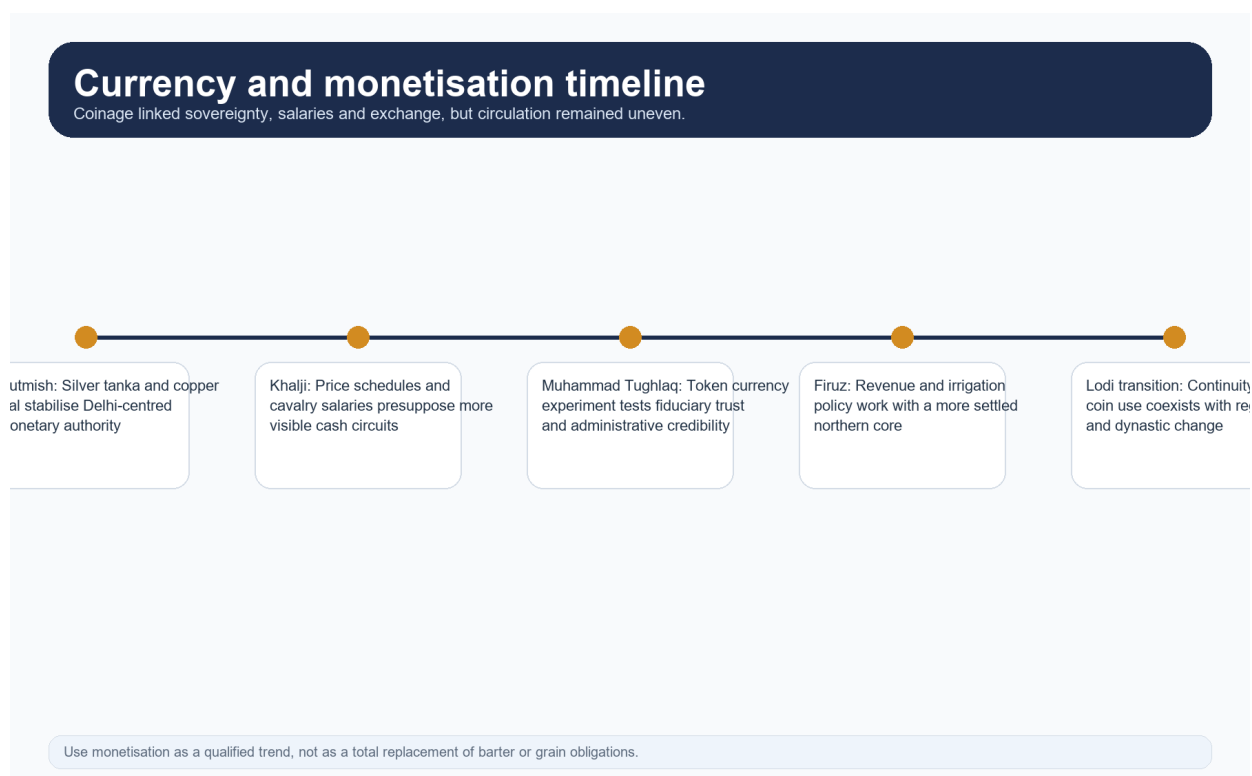
How to use them: Frame the answer through Currency; define trust, connect uneven monetisation with tanka to explain the mechanism, and use jital for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Iltutmish's silver **tanka** and copper **jital** became important markers of stable Delhi-centred monetary authority. Satish Chandra's concise source sometimes uses *dirham* language for copper units, which itself is a reminder that terminology may vary by narrative register.

[FACT] Monetisation was real enough for cavalry salaries, market schedules and hundis to matter. It was also real enough for Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency failure to become a classic problem of administrative trust.

[ANALYSIS] Yet Topic 07 must reject the tidy textbook story of a linear march to a fully monetised economy. Grain, share, cash conversion and local variation coexisted. Coin circulation expanded possibilities; it did not wipe out all non-cash relations.

[LIMIT] Token currency is a bounded example, not the whole monetary history of the Sultanate. It must never be described as paper currency.



15. Currency and monetisation timeline

Monetisation visual. It places stable coinage, fiduciary experiment and uneven circulation on the same timeline.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CURRENCY, TRUST AND UNEVEN MONETISATION

START / CONCEPT: Currency, trust and uneven monetisation

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Currency · trust · uneven monetisation · tanka · jital · Iltutmish's

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: It was also real enough for Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency failure to become a classic problem of administrative trust.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Iltutmish's silver tanka and copper jital became important markers of stable Delhi-centred monetary authority.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: monetisation was real enough for cavalry salaries, market schedules and hundis to matter.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Token currency is a bounded example, not the whole monetary history of the Sultanate.

SESSION 16 - URBANISATION: CAPITALS, QASBAS, PROVINCIAL TOWNS AND THE URBAN-REVIVAL DEBATE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: [DEBATE] Historians disagree over how transformative this was.

Technical definition: Urban growth under the Sultanate is best explained through demand plus connection.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

[DEBATE] Historians disagree over how transformative this was.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Urbanisation
- capitals
- qasbas
- provincial towns
- the urban-revival debate
- demand plus connection

How to use them: Frame the answer through Urbanisation; define capitals, connect qasbas with provincial towns to explain the mechanism, and use the urban-revival debate for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Delhi and Daulatabad receive dramatic attention in the sources, but the urban world was much wider: Lahore, Multan, Kara, Lakhnauti, Anhilwara/Patan, Cambay/Khambayat and Sonargaon all appear as important nodes.

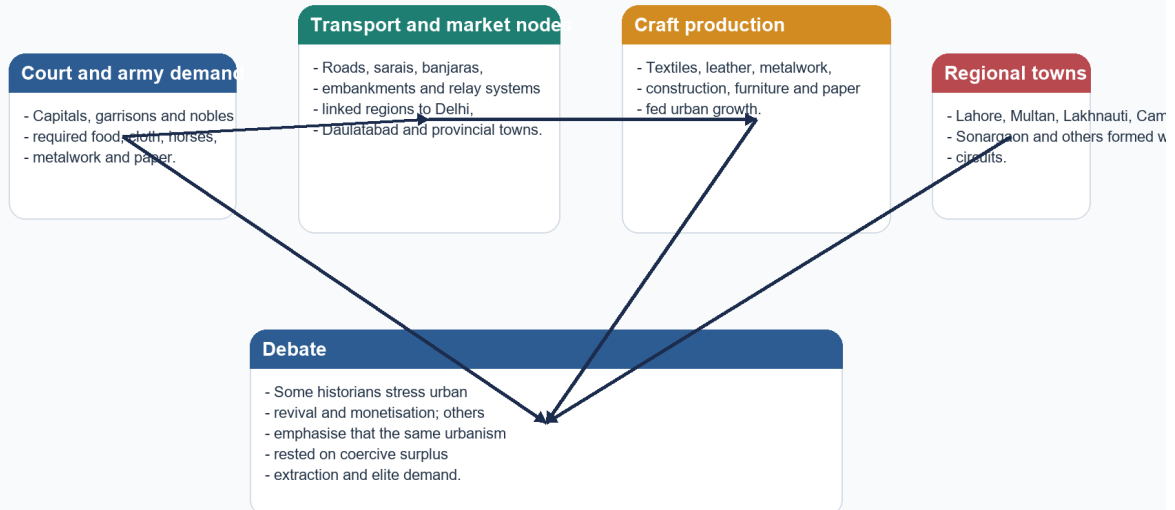
[FACT] Many towns grew around garrisons, but they did not remain mere camps. Administrators, clerks, artisans, merchants, scholars, slaves and performers created mixed urban societies.

[ANALYSIS] Urban growth under the Sultanate is best explained through **demand plus connection**. Court and army demand pulled in food and craft goods; merchants and routes widened exchange; the growth of a money nexus and specialised production fed further urban concentration.

[DEBATE] Historians disagree over how transformative this was. Topic 07 therefore uses the phrase 'urban revival' or 'urban expansion' more safely than a mechanically celebratory 'urban revolution' without qualification.

Urbanisation: demand and supply network

Court consumption and trade fed each other.



Process flow: arrows show dominant movement of power, revenue or argument.

16. Urbanisation demand-supply network

Urbanisation visual. It connects towns to armies, merchants, craft and rural surplus rather than treating them in isolation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - URBANISATION: CAPITALS, QASBAS, PROVINCIAL TOWNS AND THE URBAN-REVIVAL DEBATE

START / CONCEPT: Urbanisation: capitals, qasbas, provincial towns and the urban-revival debate

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Urbanisation · capitals · qasbas · provincial towns · the urban-revival debate · demand plus connection

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Urban growth under the Sultanate is best explained through demand plus connection.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Delhi and Daulatabad receive dramatic attention in the sources, but the urban world was much wider: Lahore, Multan, Kara, Lakhnauti, Anhilwara/Patan, Cambay/Khambayat and Sonargaon all appear as important nodes.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Topic 07 therefore uses the phrase 'urban revival' or 'urban expansion' more safely than a mechanically celebratory 'urban revolution' without qualification.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: [DEBATE] Historians disagree over how transformative this was.

SESSION 17 - CRAFTS AND TECHNOLOGY: DIFFUSION, ADAPTATION AND SCALE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The better story is diffusion through existing craft skill, local demand, state projects and regional adaptation.

Technical definition: The OCR evidence is strongest for paper-making, the wider use of the spinning wheel, the cotton-carder's bow, improved looms, water-lifting devices, lime mortar, arches, domes, armour, saddles and other metal crafts.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The better story is diffusion through existing craft skill, local demand, state projects and regional adaptation.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Crafts
- technology
- diffusion
- adaptation
- scale
- The OCR evidence

How to use them: Frame the answer through Crafts; define technology, connect diffusion with adaptation to explain the mechanism, and use scale for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The OCR evidence is strongest for paper-making, the wider use of the spinning wheel, the cotton-carder's bow, improved looms, water-lifting devices, lime mortar, arches, domes, armour, saddles and other metal crafts.

[FACT] The advanced OCR treats paper-making as a new industry and places the widespread use of the spinning wheel in India by the middle of the fourteenth century, with caution on origins and transfer routes.

[ANALYSIS] The real historical value of these techniques lies in social effect. Textile efficiency, easier record-keeping, deeper irrigation in some areas, larger building projects and better cavalry equipment changed state capacity, urban demand and labour use.

[DEBATE] The wrong story is one-way civilisation from outside to passive India. The better story is diffusion through existing craft skill, local demand, state projects and regional adaptation.

Crafts and technology: evidence matrix

Diffusion, adaptation and scale must be distinguished.

Technique / craft	What can be said safely	Built-in caution
Paper-making	A new industry expanded under the Sultanate with rag-based technology entering India after	Do not treat it as a sudden literacy revolution for all.
Spinning wheel and cotton-carder's bow	Wider use improved yarn preparation and textile efficiency by the fourteenth century.	Chronology is cautious: diffusion, not one-day invention.
Rahat / saqiya	Water-lifting improvement helped deeper irrigation in some regions.	Often mislabeled simply as the Persian wheel; adoption was uneven.
Lime mortar, arch and dome	Construction technology supported larger vaults and monuments.	Indian craftsmen, reuse and local experimentation mattered.
Metallurgy, saddles and armour	Horse warfare, stirrups and armour expanded metal demand.	Technology served military and elite goals first.
Enamelled tiles and building finish	Visible in later Sultanate urban aesthetics.	Do not exaggerate into total stylistic replacement.

Reading rule

UPSC's 2023 technology question is best answered through social

effect, not through a bare list of devices. Comparison is not through analytical, not timeless absolutes.

17. Crafts and technology evidence matrix

Technology matrix. It combines what can be said securely with the cautions demanded by the 2023 GS-I question.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CRAFTS AND TECHNOLOGY: DIFFUSION, ADAPTATION AND SCALE

START / CONCEPT: Crafts and technology: diffusion, adaptation and scale

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Crafts · technology · diffusion · adaptation · scale · The OCR evidence

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The advanced OCR treats paper-making as a new industry and places the widespread use of the spinning wheel in India by the middle of the fourteenth century, with caution on origins and transfer routes.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The OCR evidence is strongest for paper-making, the wider use of the spinning wheel, the cotton-carder's bow, improved looms, water-lifting devices, lime mortar, arches, domes, armour, saddles and other metal crafts.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: textile efficiency, easier record-keeping, deeper irrigation in some areas, larger building projects and better...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The better story is diffusion through existing craft skill, local demand, state projects and regional adaptation.

SESSION 18 - INLAND AND MARITIME TRADE: CORRIDORS, SARAI AND HORSES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Inland and maritime trade: corridors, sarais and horses comprises Inland, maritime trade and corridors as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Trade was not a decorative add-on to politics.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Trees, sarais and relay systems show that transport infrastructure was a political concern.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Inland
- maritime trade
- corridors
- sarais
- horses
- Peshawar-Delhi-Sonargaon

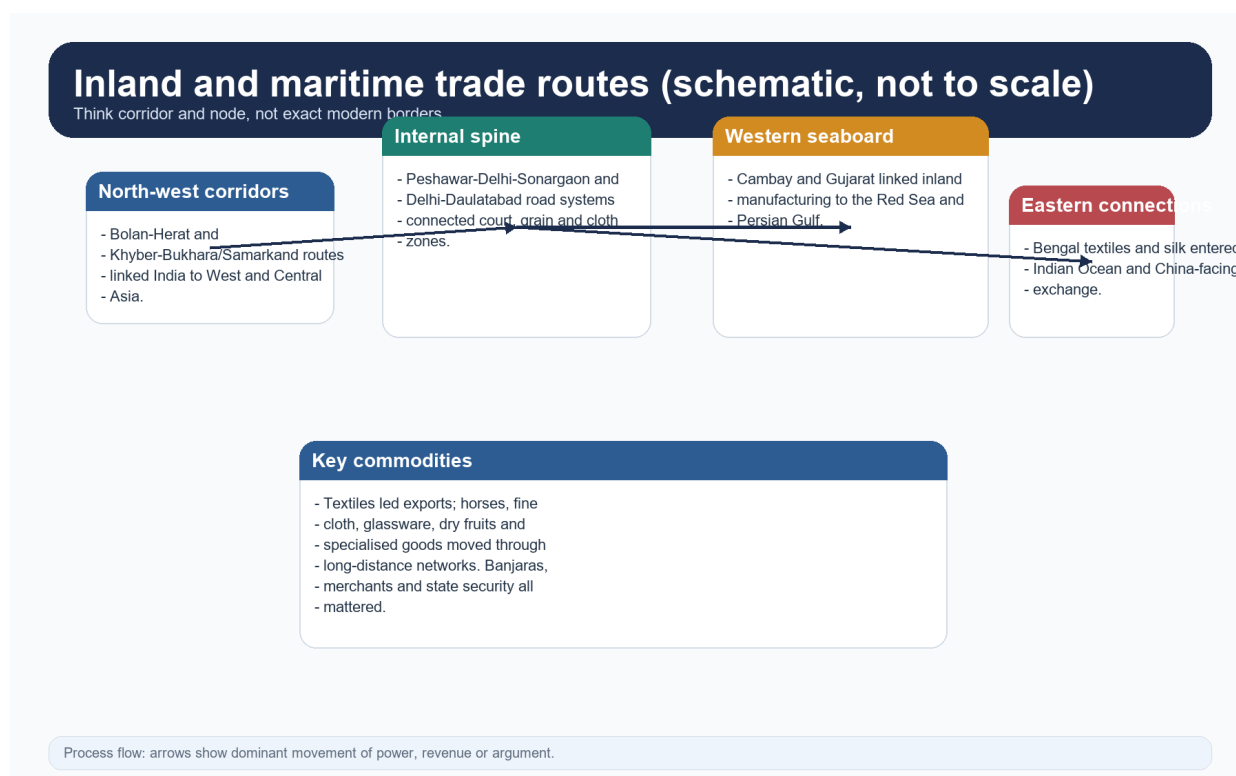
How to use them: Frame the answer through Inland; define maritime trade, connect corridors with sarais to explain the mechanism, and use horses for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The Sultanate inherited and expanded long-distance trade through north-west routes, internal roads and maritime exchange. The sources repeatedly mention the Peshawar-Delhi-Sonargaon axis, the road to Daulatabad, and western links through Gujarat.

[FACT] Trees, sarais and relay systems show that transport infrastructure was a political concern. Horses remained a vital import; textiles remained the leading export cluster.

[ANALYSIS] Trade history belongs inside the state narrative because the army, the nobility and the urban population all depended on regular movement of grain, animals, cloth and money. Trade was not a decorative add-on to politics.

[LIMIT] Route diagrams are schematic and not to scale. They indicate corridor logic, not exact continuous border control by Delhi.



18. Inland and maritime trade route schematic

Trade-route visual. It emphasises corridors and nodes, not false cartographic precision.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - INLAND AND MARITIME TRADE: CORRIDORS, SARAIS AND HORSES

START / CONCEPT: Inland and maritime trade: corridors, sarais and horses

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Inland · maritime trade · corridors · sarais · horses · Peshawar-Delhi-Sonargaon

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The sources repeatedly mention the Peshawar-Delhi-Sonargaon axis, the road to Daulatabad, and western links through Gujarat.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Trade was not a decorative add-on to politics.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Route diagrams are schematic and not to scale.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Trees, sarais and relay systems show that transport infrastructure was a political concern.

SESSION 19 - MERCHANTS, BROKERS, BANJARAS AND CREDIT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Merchant initiative, finance and transport were indispensable, even where the state regulated, taxed or supervised their activity.

Technical definition: Wealthy merchants could lend heavily even to nobles.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Merchant initiative, finance and transport were indispensable, even where the state regulated, taxed or supervised their activity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Merchants

- brokers
- banjaras
- credit
- Hundis
- intervention did not erase market society

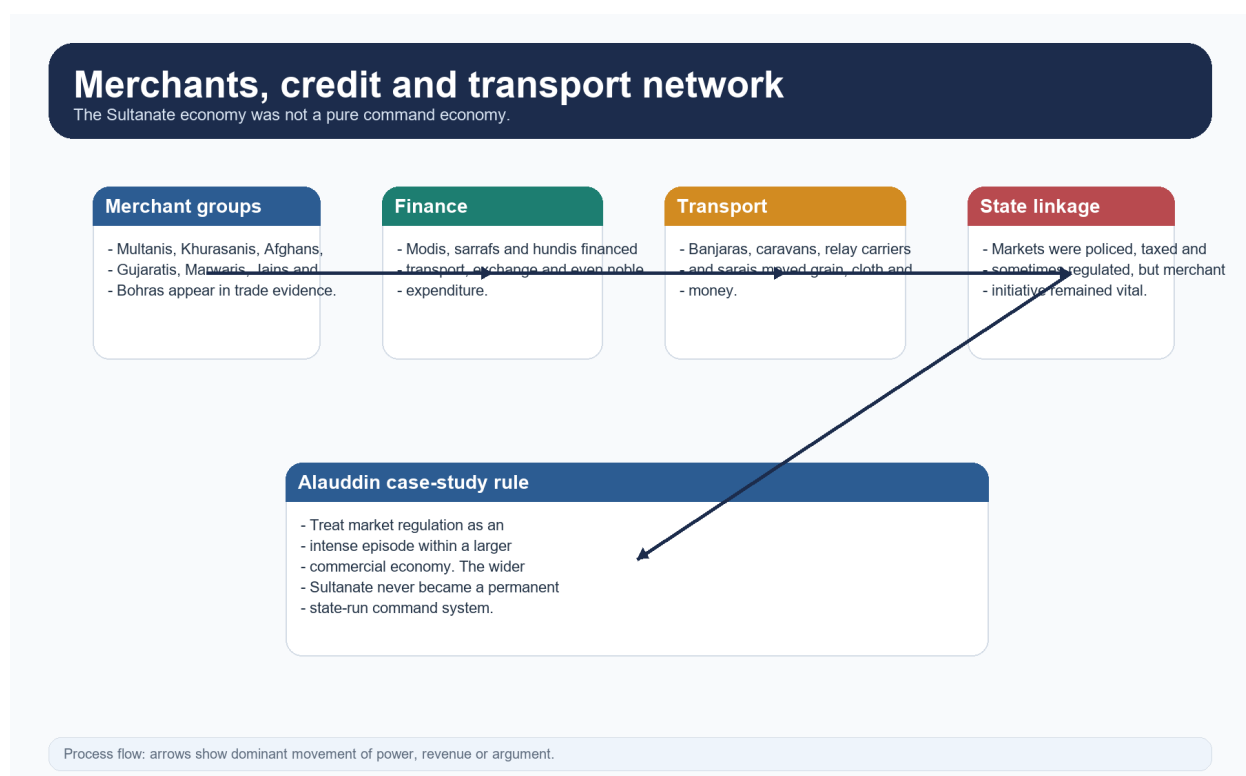
How to use them: Frame the answer through Merchants; define brokers, connect banjaras with credit to explain the mechanism, and use Hundis for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] The OCR and Topic 07 advanced owner identify Multanis, Khurasanis, Afghans, Gujaratis, Marwaris, Jains and Bohras as important commercial actors, though in different settings and degrees. Wealthy merchants could lend heavily even to nobles.

[FACT] **Hundis**, money-changing and sarrafs mattered for long-distance finance, transport and even storage of noble wealth. Banjaras carried grain and were central to provisioning mechanisms.

[ANALYSIS] This evidence blocks the habit of reducing the Sultanate economy to state extraction alone. Merchant initiative, finance and transport were indispensable, even where the state regulated, taxed or supervised their activity.

[DEBATE] Alauddin's controls are best handled as a capital-centred military-fiscal episode inside this wider commercial system. Topic 07 therefore insists: **intervention did not erase market society**.



19. Merchant-credit-transport network

Commerce visual. It shows how merchants, financiers and transporters mediated between countryside, town and state.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MERCHANTS, BROKERS, BANJARAS AND CREDIT

START / CONCEPT: Merchants, brokers, banjaras and credit

|

↓

EXACT TERMS: Merchants · brokers · banjaras · credit · Hundis · intervention did not erase market society

|

↓

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Wealthy merchants could lend heavily even to nobles.

|

↓

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Banjaras carried grain and were central to provisioning mechanisms.

|

↓

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: [DEBATE] Alauddin's controls are best handled as a capital-centred military-fiscal episode inside this wider...

|

↓

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Merchant initiative, finance and transport were indispensable, even where the state regulated, taxed or supervised their activity.

SESSION 20 - SOCIAL GROUPS, CASTE AND NON-CENSUS HIERARCHY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Social groups are analytical labels, not exact population measures.

Technical definition: The sources are strongest on elites, yet they also reveal sharp social inequality.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Social groups are analytical labels, not exact population measures.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Social groups**
- **caste**
- **non-census hierarchy**
- **overlapping social layers**
- **The sources**
- **At**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Social groups; define caste, connect non-census hierarchy with overlapping social layers to explain the mechanism, and use The sources for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Sultanate society included rulers, nobles, ulema, officials, soldiers, peasants, artisans, merchants, slaves, mendicants, entertainers and service groups. The sources are strongest on elites, yet they also reveal sharp social inequality.

[FACT] Smriti writers preserved Brahmanical hierarchy and restrictions on many lower groups. At the same time, the urban world and state service created more mixed settings than a simple textbook pyramid suggests.

[ANALYSIS] The historian should therefore think in terms of **overlapping social layers**, not a neat medieval census chart. Class, status, religion, occupation, gender and locality interacted differently in towns, villages, courts and frontiers.

[LIMIT] Social groups are analytical labels, not exact population measures. The archive rarely allows precise numerical breakdowns.

Social groups: heuristic matrix, not a census pyramid

The labels organise evidence; they do not count people exactly.

Layer	Included groups	Safe caution
Ruling / service elite	Sultan, nobles, ulema, high officials, military commanders, court household	Status shifted with office and patronage.
Local landed power	Rais, rawats, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhurs and later-zamindar type intermediaries	Names and weight varied regionally.
Urban commercial	Merchants, sarrafs, shopkeepers, brokers and transporters	We know more about the wealthy than the petty dealer.
Craft and labour	Artisans, builders, weavers, leather workers, labourers, servants and performers	Wage data is patchy and urban-biased.
Dependent and marginal groups	Slaves, mendicants, debtors, service castes, forest-edge communities and nomads	Sources are often silent or moralising.

Reading rule

Use social groups to map hierarchy and interaction, not to draw a

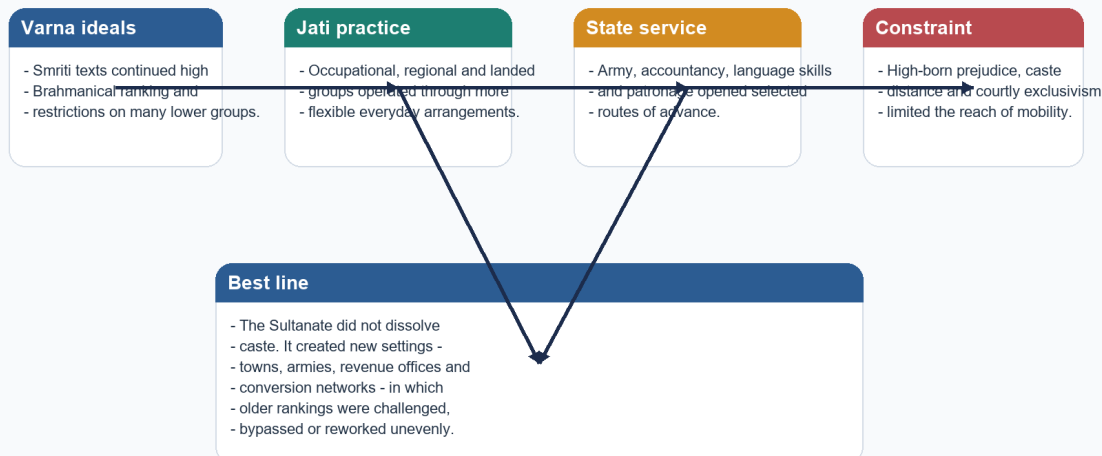
Comparison of modern demographic charts as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

20. Social groups non-census matrix

Social-matrix visual. It organises evidence without pretending to produce a medieval census.

Caste, jati and limited mobility

Hierarchy persisted, but office, migration and towns altered opportunity.



Process flow: arrows show dominant movement of power, revenue or argument.

21. Caste, jati and mobility process

Mobility visual. It shows why state service and towns mattered without dissolving hierarchy.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SOCIAL GROUPS, CASTE AND NON-CENSUS HIERARCHY

START / CONCEPT: Social groups, caste and non-census hierarchy

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Social groups · caste · non-census hierarchy · overlapping social layers · The sources
· At

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The historian should therefore think in terms of overlapping social layers,
not a neat medieval census chart.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The sources are strongest on elites, yet they also reveal sharp social
inequality.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: at the same time, the urban world
and state service created more mixed settings...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Social groups are analytical labels, not exact population measures.

SESSION 21 - HINDUS, MUSLIMS AND CONVERSION: DIFFERENTIATED COMMUNITIES, NOT STATIC BLOCS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The best social frame is therefore one of differentiated communities in unequal interaction.

Technical definition: The OCR is explicit that Muslim society itself remained internally divided among Turks, Iranians, Afghans and Indian Muslims.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The best social frame is therefore one of differentiated communities in unequal interaction.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Hindus**
- **Muslims**
- **conversion**
- **differentiated communities**
- **not static blocs**
- **differentiated communities in unequal interaction**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Hindus; define Muslims, connect conversion with differentiated communities to explain the mechanism, and use not static blocs for the decisive comparison or qualification.

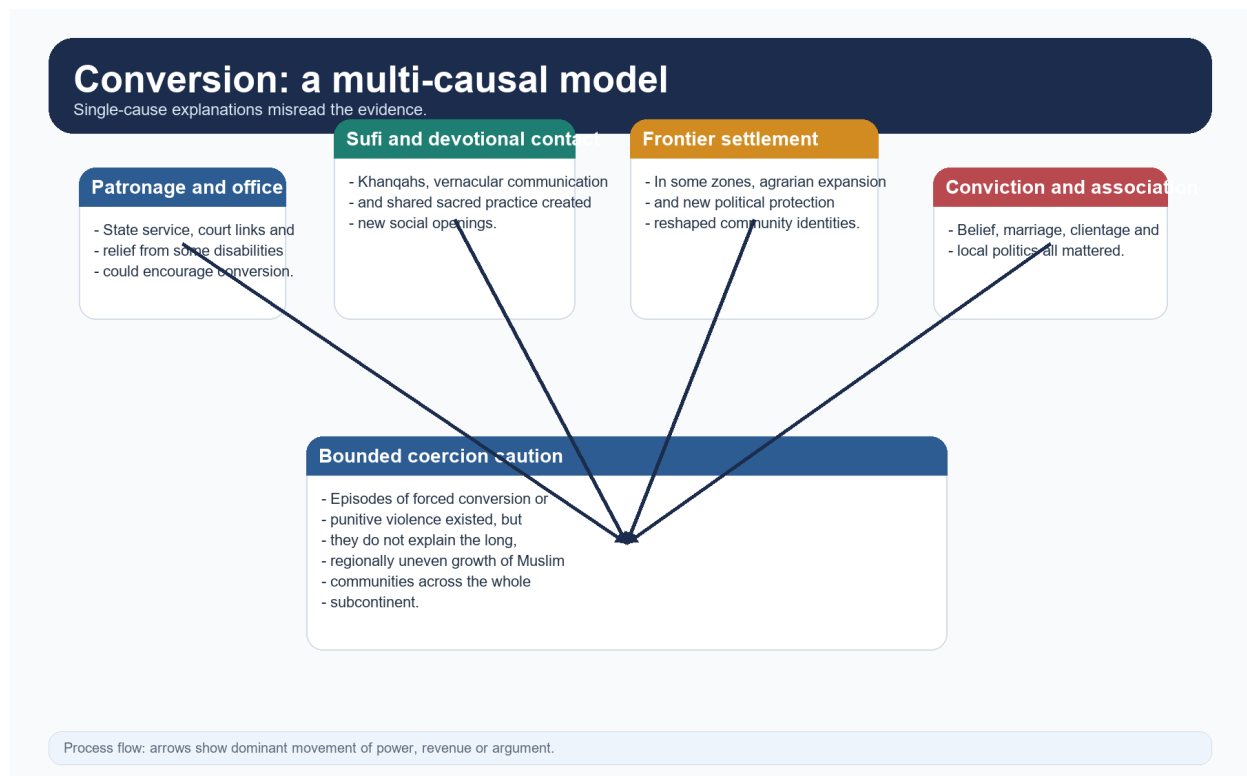
[FACT] The OCR is explicit that Muslim society itself remained internally divided among Turks, Iranians, Afghans and Indian Muslims. The advanced source uses *ashraf* and *ajlaf* language for status differentiation and shows discrimination against many converts and occupational groups.

[FACT] The concise OCR is equally explicit that Hindus were not absent from Sultanate power. They remained crucial in local administration, revenue collection, trade and even military service. Most nobles kept Hindu managers, and the local administrative machinery stayed largely in Hindu hands.

[ANALYSIS] The best social frame is therefore one of **differentiated communities in unequal interaction**. There was tension, hierarchy and violence; there was also dependence, employment, translation and shared urban space.

[ANALYSIS] Conversion should be treated as multi-causal: patronage, social mobility, service, belief, Sufi contact, political association and in some places frontier settlement all mattered. Bounded coercive episodes existed, but they do not explain the whole pattern.

[LIMIT] Topic 07 deliberately avoids a mass-conversion or total-exclusion narrative because neither is supported by the evidence base used here.



22. Conversion multi-causal model

Conversion visual. It keeps political, social, devotional and regional mechanisms together and refuses single-cause explanation.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - HINDUS, MUSLIMS AND CONVERSION: DIFFERENTIATED COMMUNITIES, NOT STATIC BLOCS

```

START / CONCEPT: Hindus, Muslims and conversion: differentiated communities, not static blocs
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Hindus • Muslims • conversion • differentiated communities • not static blocs •
differentiated communities in unequal interaction
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Topic 07 deliberately avoids a mass-conversion or total-exclusion narrative
because neither is supported by the evidence base used here.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The concise OCR is equally explicit that Hindus were not absent from
Sultanate power.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Bounded coercive episodes existed, but they do not explain the whole
pattern.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The best social frame is therefore one of differentiated communities
in unequal interaction.

```

SESSION 22 - SLAVERY, GENDER AND EVERYDAY MATERIAL INEQUALITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Slavery, gender and everyday material inequality comprises Slavery, gender and everyday material inequality as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Slavery, gender and everyday material inequality is analysed by relating Slavery to gender, then testing the relationship through everyday material inequality and purdah.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The OCR also shows that slavery lowered the status of free labour and helped structure elite comfort.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Slavery
- gender
- everyday material inequality
- purdah
- Firuz's
- The OCR

How to use them: Frame the answer through Slavery; define gender, connect everyday material inequality with purdah to explain the mechanism, and use Firuz's for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Slavery remained an important part of Sultanate social life. Prisoners of war, purchased slaves, domestic slaves, artisanal slaves and bodyguards all appear in the evidence. Firuz's reported 1,80,000 slaves and 12,000 trained artisans must remain labelled as chronicle-scale claims, not audited census truth.

[FACT] The OCR also shows that slavery lowered the status of free labour and helped structure elite comfort. Some military slaves rose high, but most slaves did not.

[FACT] On gender, upper-class seclusion or **purdah** spread more widely in the Sultanate centuries, especially among courtly and elite groups. Yet the evidence itself treats this as classed and situational. It does not justify a universal rule for all women.

[DEBATE] Sati, jauhar, widow rights, property claims, royal women and women's labour must therefore be handled on an evidence ladder: prescription, elite norm, specific episode, then careful inference. Topic 07 does not romanticise either complete repression or complete emancipation.

Slavery forms under the Sultanate

Do not flatten all slavery into one social experience.

Form	Typical role	Caution
Elite military slavery	Household-trained commanders and guards with chances of office and manumission.	Politically powerful but socially narrow.
Domestic slavery	Household service, care, companionship, maintenance of elite comfort.	Could still be harsh and degrading.
Artisanal / karkhana slavery	Work in workshops, stores, construction and court manufacture, especially under Firuz.	Demand rose with state projects and elite consumption.
War captives and markets	Capture in war, resale in markets and redistribution by rulers and nobles.	Chronicle numbers are often inflated.
Bodyguard / armed corps	Personal protection and palace politics.	Firuz's corps later showed king-making danger rather than stable institutional strength.

Reading rule

Manumission mattered, but it never erased the degradation built into

Comparisons: ~~bondage~~ treat category labels as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

23. Slavery forms comparison

Slavery visual. It keeps elite military slavery distinct from domestic, artisanal and captive forms.

Gender evidence ladder

Move from prescription to practice with caution.

Prescription: Smriti, juristic and moral texts tell us what male authors wanted women to do.

Elite norm: Purdah/seclusion spread among upper classes and some Hindu elites, but not uniform.

Political exception: Raziya, royal mothers, noble households and market women show agency within hierarchy.

Caution: Sati, jauhar and veiling are best treated as classed and situational; not universal medieval habits.

Reading ladder: move from secure evidence to larger argument with caution.

24. Gender evidence ladder

Gender visual. It shows why prescription, elite norm and lived practice must be kept separate.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SLAVERY, GENDER AND EVERYDAY MATERIAL INEQUALITY

START / CONCEPT: Slavery, gender and everyday material inequality

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Slavery · gender · everyday material inequality · purdah · Firuz's · The OCR

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Firuz's reported 1,80,000 slaves and 12,000 trained artisans must remain labelled as chronicle-scale claims, not audited census truth.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It does not justify a universal rule for all women.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: [DEBATE] Sati, jauhar, widow rights, property claims, royal women and women's labour must therefore...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The OCR also shows that slavery lowered the status of free labour and helped structure elite comfort.

SESSION 23 - EDUCATION, LANGUAGE, ULEMA, SUFIS AND SOCIAL INTERACTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: 'Composite culture' is a useful phrase only if mechanism is supplied - language contact, service, translation, shared urbanity, music or shrine interaction - not if it becomes a slogan.

Technical definition: Topic 07 uses Sufis and ulema not to retell Topic 10, but to explain how language, legitimacy and social contact worked.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Topic 07 uses Sufis and ulema not to retell Topic 10, but to explain how language, legitimacy and social contact worked.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Education
- language
- ulema
- Sufis
- social interaction
- Persian

How to use them: Frame the answer through Education; define language, connect ulema with Sufis to explain the mechanism, and use social interaction for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[FACT] Maktabas, madrasas, mosques, khanqahs, courtly scholarship, Sanskrit learning and local teaching traditions coexisted. The spread of paper-making made record-keeping and manuscripts easier, but did not automatically democratise learning.

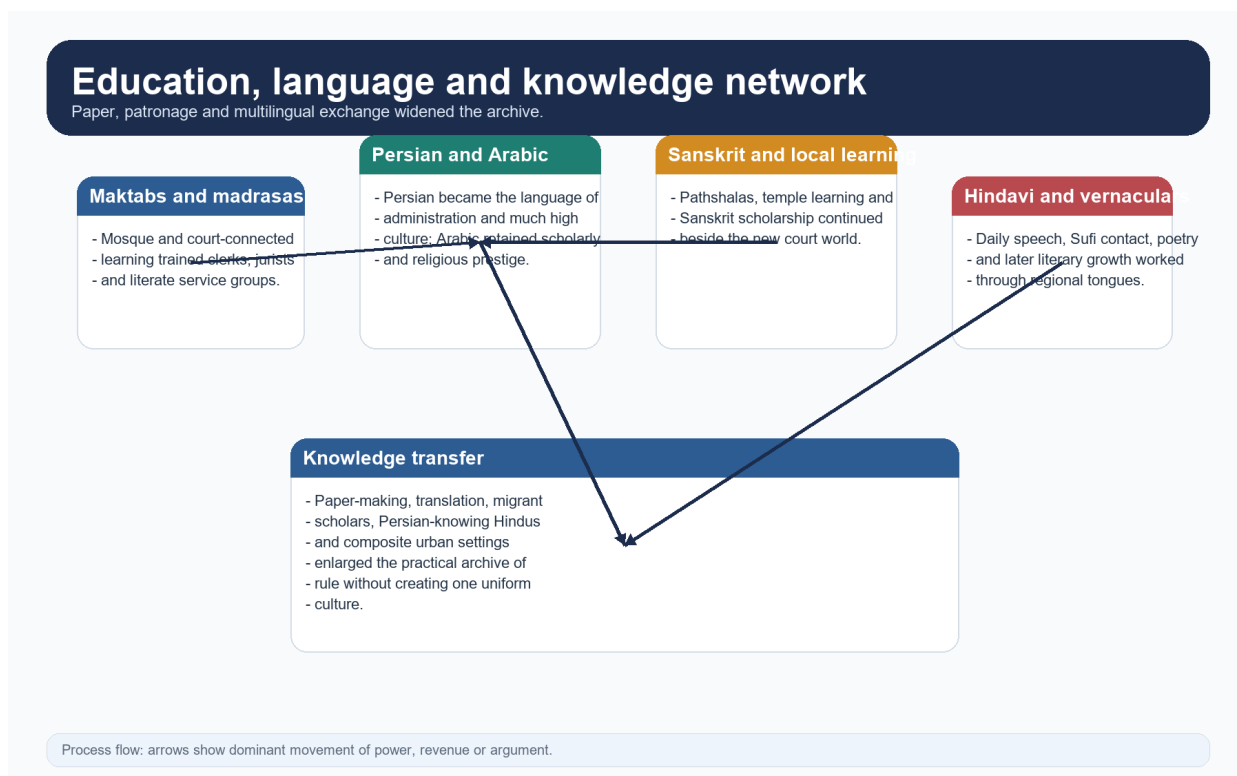
[FACT] Persian became the leading language of administration and much elite literary production; Arabic retained high religious prestige; Hindavi and other vernaculars expanded in everyday speech, Sufi conversation, poetic expression and later literary growth.

[FACT] The advanced OCR's note on Persian-knowing Hindus is especially important. By the Tughlaq period, a class of Hindus trained in Persian was entering service, showing that administrative culture could widen across community boundaries.

[ANALYSIS] Topic 07 uses Sufis and ulema not to retell Topic 10, but to explain how language, legitimacy and social contact worked. Chishti use of Hindavi, saint-yogi interaction, juristic office and court patronage all helped mediate the

social life of rule.

[LIMIT] 'Composite culture' is a useful phrase only if mechanism is supplied - language contact, service, translation, shared urbanity, music or shrine interaction - not if it becomes a slogan.



25. Education and language knowledge network

Knowledge-network visual. It links institutions, paper, languages and service culture rather than isolating them.

State, ulema and Sufis: a relationship matrix

Political authority, legal legitimacy and saintly charisma never aligned perfectly.

Ruler / tendency	Ulema relationship	Sufi / wider social implication
Ilutmish and Balban	Needed juristic language and symbols but retained sovereign choice.	Delhi's prestige also grew through migrant scholars and saints.
Alauddin Khalji	Refused to let sharia alone govern statecraft; reason of state was explicit.	Urban order and security mattered more than saint-state romance.
Muhammad bin Tughlaq	Contested by sections of ulema; sought caliphal prestige under pressure.	Could engage yogis, Jains and Sufis without ceasing to be coercive.
Firuz Tughlaq	Moved closer to juristic approval, separate jizya and moral policing.	Translation and charity coexisted with sharper orthodoxy.
Lodi phase	Orthodoxy, Persian learning and practical administration coexisted uneasily.	Do not reduce the period to either seamless tolerance or perpetual persecution.

Reading rule

Topic 10 owns Bhakti-Sufi movements in depth; Topic 07 uses them only to explain social and political interaction.

Comparison is not only to explain social and analytical, not timeless absolutes.

26. State-ulema-Sufi relationship matrix

Relationship visual. It keeps juristic authority, saintly charisma and royal expediency analytically separate.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EDUCATION, LANGUAGE, ULEMA, SUFIS AND SOCIAL INTERACTION

START / CONCEPT: Education, language, ulema, Sufis and social interaction

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Education · language · ulema · Sufis · social interaction · Persian

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: 'Composite culture' is a useful phrase only if mechanism is supplied - language contact, service, translation, shared urbanity, music or shrine interaction - not if it becomes a slogan.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Persian became the leading language of administration and much elite literary production; Arabic retained high religious prestige; Hindavi and other vernaculars expanded in everyday speech, Sufi conversation, poetic expression and later literary growth.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: chishti use of Hindavi, saint-yogi interaction, juristic office and court patronage all helped mediate...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Topic 07 uses Sufis and ulema not to retell Topic 10, but to explain how language, legitimacy and social contact worked.

SESSION 24 - SYNTHESIS AND HISTORIOGRAPHY: CENTRALISATION, FEUDALISM, URBAN CHANGE AND SOURCES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Synthesis and historiography: centralisation, feudalism, urban change and sources comprises Synthesis, historiography and centralisation as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: [DEBATE] Was there an urban revolution?

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Synthesis and historiography: centralisation, feudalism, urban change and sources comprises Synthesis, historiography and centralisation as its core connected dimensions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Synthesis**
- **historiography**
- **centralisation**
- **feudalism**
- **urban change**
- **sources**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Synthesis; define historiography, connect centralisation with feudalism to explain the mechanism, and use urban change for the decisive comparison or qualification.

[DEBATE] Was the Sultanate centralised? Yes, at the apex; unevenly, below. This is why the strongest answer speaks of **centralising aspiration plus negotiated sovereignty**.

[DEBATE] Was iqta feudalism? The comparison can illuminate service-linked assignment, but breaks down if it ignores state superiority, transfer, audit and the changing political meaning of assignment over time.

[DEBATE] Was there an urban revolution? Town growth, monetisation, crafts and trade were substantial, but their energy rested on agrarian extraction and hierarchy. Growth and coercion must therefore be read together.

[DEBATE] Did technology simply arrive from outside? No. The better frame is diffusion and adaptation through artisans, courts, merchants and local needs. The same caution applies to language and culture.

[DEBATE] Was the state religious or secular? Neither label is adequate by itself. Sharia, caliphal idiom, jurists, zawabit, royal expediency and local custom coexisted in changing proportion.

[FACT] The core source matrix remains: Barani, Minhaj, Amir Khusrau, Ibn Battuta, Isami, Afif, coins, inscriptions, architecture, archaeology and regional texts. Every good answer should move from named evidence to mechanism to qualification to verdict.

Was the Sultanate centralised?

Aspirational centralisation and negotiated sovereignty existed together.

Argument	Evidence for it	Counter-limit
Centralised apex	Sultan, differentiated offices, coinage, khutba, intelligence and cavalry finance point to a strong centre.	Distance, ecology and provincial military resources limited uniform enforcement.
Negotiated polity	Muqtis, chiefs, khuts, muqaddams and urban brokers translated orders into practice.	Negotiation does not mean absence of coercion.
Dynastic variation	Alauddin tightened, Muhammad strained, Firuz softened and Lodis bargained differently.	No one diagram fits the whole Sultanate.

Reading rule

Best exam verdict: centralised at the top, unevenly realised below.

Comparison matrix: treat category labels as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

27. Centralisation debate

Centralisation visual. It turns a yes-or-no question into a layered argument.

Urbanisation and economic historiography

Growth and coercion are not mutually exclusive explanations.

Historiographical emphasis	What it highlights	What must still be added
Urban revival / monetisation	Towns, trade, currency, artisans, road security, merchant credit and long-distance textile demand.	Need to specify who benefited and how unevenly.
Military-fiscal extraction	Heavy agrarian demand, elite consumption and coercive transfer of surplus powered towns.	This alone cannot explain craft vitality and maritime links.
Technology diffusion	Paper, spinning wheel, water-lifting, lime mortar and military gear expanded capability.	Diffusion was adapted locally and rarely universal.
Social inequality	Cheap grain for some coexisted with hard artisan wages and peasant vulnerability.	Urban growth did not equal social justice.

Reading rule

Use historians such as Irfan Habib, Satish Chandra and K.M. Ashraf accurately and only for claims they are actually known to

Comparison matrix: treat category labels as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

28. Urban revolution and economic historiography matrix

Historiography visual. It contrasts growth, extraction and technology without forcing false choices.

Source criticism matrix

Genre is not a footnote - it is the beginning of interpretation.

Source	Best use	Key limitation
Barani	Political theory, elite anxiety, Alauddin's regulations and aristocratic prelude.	Late, normative and hostile to low-born advancement.
Minhaj, Amir Khusrau, Isami, Afif	Campaigns, court atmosphere and reign-specific episodes.	Patronage, literary flourish or displacement shape all of them.
Ibn Battuta	Urban life, roads, gifts, punishments, products and travel description.	Attracted to the vivid and unusual; not a census survey.
Coins and inscriptions	Titulature, minting and public claims.	Claimed authority does not map actual reach.
Architecture and archaeology	Technical change, spatial claim, labour and patronage.	Meaning is never transparent from form alone.
Regional texts and later memory	Local perspective and afterlife of events.	Chronological distance requires separation from contemporary record.

Reading rule

Answer pattern: claim -> named source -> what it proves ->

Comparison -> limitation -> verdict. Comparative labels as analytical, not timeless absolutes.

29. Source criticism matrix

Source matrix. It keeps genre and limitation at the centre of explanation.

GS-I answer spine for Topic 07

A repeatable high-scoring structure.

Start: Define the institution or debate and locate it in a changing Sultanate chronology.

Evidence: Name one chronicle, coin, office, market device, town or historian for each body dimension.

Mechanism: Explain how revenue, army, legitimacy, town demand or social hierarchy worked.

Qualification: Add regional unevenness, source bias or chronology caution before concluding.

Reading ladder: move from secure evidence to larger argument with caution.

30. GS-I answer spine

Answer-spine visual. It gives a repeatable structure for administrative, economic and social questions.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SYNTHESIS AND HISTORIOGRAPHY: CENTRALISATION, FEUDALISM, URBAN CHANGE AND SOURCES

START / CONCEPT: Synthesis and historiography: centralisation, feudalism, urban change and sources

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Synthesis · historiography · centralisation · feudalism · urban change · sources

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The better frame is diffusion and adaptation through artisans, courts, merchants and local needs.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The comparison can illuminate service-linked assignment, but breaks down if it ignores state superiority, transfer, audit and the changing political meaning of assignment over time.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Town growth, monetisation, crafts and trade were substantial, but their energy rested on agrarian extraction and hierarchy.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Synthesis and historiography: centralisation, feudalism, urban change and sources comprises Synthesis, historiography and centralisation as its core connected dimensions.

SESSION 25 - BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The live page is a teaching bridge only.

Technical definition: The Reserve Bank of India's Medieval India coinage page was rechecked on 30 August 2026.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The live page is a teaching bridge only.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Bounded live linkage
- The Reserve Bank
- India's Medieval India
- It
- Delhi Sultanate
- This

How to use them: Frame the answer through Bounded live linkage; define The Reserve Bank, connect India's Medieval India with It to explain the mechanism, and use Delhi Sultanate for the decisive comparison or qualification.

The Reserve Bank of India's Medieval India coinage page was rechecked on 30 August 2026. It describes the consolidation of the tanka and jittal, an attempted standardisation under the Delhi Sultanate, expansion of the money economy and gold, silver and copper issues. This official numismatic bridge supports the package's coinage and monetisation section; its estimates and evaluative language are identified as RBI museum-page claims rather than universal measures of social welfare or uniform market penetration.

The live page is a teaching bridge only. Historical chronology, causation and institutional claims remain controlled by repository Markdown, OCR-searchable books and source criticism.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - BOUNDED LIVE LINKAGE

START / CONCEPT: Bounded live linkage

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Bounded live linkage · The Reserve Bank · India's Medieval India · It · Delhi Sultanate · This

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Reserve Bank of India's Medieval India coinage page was rechecked on 30 August 2026.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It describes the consolidation of the tanka and jittal, an attempted standardisation under the Delhi Sultanate, expansion of the money economy and gold, silver and copper issues.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: This official numismatic bridge supports the package's coinage and monetisation section; its estimates and evaluative language are identified as RBI museum-page claims rather than universal measures of social welfare or uniform market penetration.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The live page is a teaching bridge only.

MEDIEVAL DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Iqta, muqti, kharaj, jizya and central diwans must be matched to their precise fiscal-administrative functions.
- **Close distinction:** An iqta was not automatically private ownership or hereditary property across every reign and region.
- **Evidence / interpretation limit:** Administrative ideals, chronicler prescriptions and uneven local practice must remain analytically separate.

TOPIC 07 CLOSING CROSS-DYNASTIC INSTITUTION LEDGER

Source, law and practice

- Chronicles and normative texts must be separated from farmans/orders, inscriptions, coins, archaeology and travellers such as Ibn Battuta.
- Sultanate sovereignty used coin, khutba, court, justice and appointments; caliphal symbolism did not create modern legal sovereignty.
- Sharia norms, ulama interpretation and sultanik zawabit/state regulation interacted differently by reign.
- Department names and portfolios changed; Diwan-i Risalat is especially disputed between religious-grant and diplomatic reconstructions.

Administration, iqta and revenue

Layer	Core institutions and caution
Centre	Wizarat/wazir; Arz/ariz-i mamalik; Insha; Risalat; sadr; qazi; barid
Province/locality	wali/muqti; shiq; pargana/amil; village; khuts, muqaddams, chaudhurs
Iqta	transferable/auditable revenue-service assignment; hereditary drift varied; not private land
Revenue norms	kharaj, ushr, zakat, jizya, khams and cesses require legal-versus-practice distinction
Army	mamluk/free cavalry, iqta contingents, infantry, elephants, forts, branding/rolls and frontier logistics

Economy, society and technology

- Agrarian production, irrigation, crops, famine and state extraction differed by region; peasants and intermediaries were not homogeneous.

- Karkhanas, textiles, metals, paper and building linked village/town artisans to court, army and merchant demand.
- Towns and qasbas depended on hinterlands; transport, ports, money, hundis, brokers and international networks varied regionally.
- The urban-revolution thesis must be balanced against older settlements, regional trajectories and agrarian dependence.
- Political elites, ulama, Sufis, merchants, artisans, peasants, bandagan, women, converts, non-Muslim communities and Rajputs formed overlapping, stratified groups-not Hindu/Muslim sealed blocs.
- Slavery had domestic, military, productive and captive forms; none maps automatically onto Atlantic racial chattel slavery.
- Persian, Arabic, Sanskrit, Hindavi and regional languages interacted.
- Persian wheel, spinning wheel, paper, mortar/arch and gunpowder/firearms require diffusion/adaptation and dating cautions, not one-event introduction.

PYQ ownership

- **Direct:** 2019 Prelims Q12; 2022 Prelims Q52 (fanam; exact stem unavailable); 2023 GS-I Q12.

- **Adjacent:** 2022 Q57 -> Topic 04; 2020 GS-I Q12 -> Topic 24.

Final method: legal norm -> ruler/dynasty -> institution -> regional practice -> social/economic effect -> evidence limit -> change-over-time verdict.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Question: What is the safest opening description of Topic 07?

- A. It studies institutions as changing, negotiated and regionally uneven across the Sultanate rather than repeating ruler biographies.
- B. It treats the Delhi Sultanate as a finished modern bureaucracy from 1206 onward.
- C. It replaces administration with only art and architecture.
- D. It is a single-reign summary of Alauddin's reforms.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The topic is cross-dynastic and thematic; reduction to one ruler or one administrative diagram is exactly the trap to avoid.

Learning MCQ 02

Question: Which statement best captures Sultanate state formation?

- A. Persianate symbols replaced all local institutions overnight.
- B. Military conquest created openings, but durable rule depended on court forms, local intermediaries and inherited agrarian structures.
- C. Once Delhi won a battle, countryside administration became automatic.
- D. State formation was purely urban and detached from villages.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The strongest answer links cavalry and forts to revenue, local collaboration and social continuities.

Learning MCQ 03

Question: How should caliphal recognition be interpreted in Sultanate answers?

- A. As irrelevant decorative theology with no political use.
- B. As proof that the caliph governed India directly.
- C. As symbolic recognition that could enhance standing but did not by itself create army, territory or revenue power.
- D. As a permanent legal chain preventing rulers from issuing their own regulations.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Ilututish and later rulers used caliphal idiom, but practical sovereignty rested elsewhere.

Learning MCQ 04

Question: Which office statement is correct?

- A. The ariz was the empire's supreme sovereign judge.
- B. The Diwan-i-Insha permanently handled irrigation canals.
- C. The Diwan-i-Risalat had one universally fixed portfolio in every reign.
- D. The ariz or Diwan-i-Arz supervised the military department, but the sultan remained commander-in-chief.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This question tests against projecting later or unrelated portfolios onto Sultanate offices.

Learning MCQ 05

Question: What is the best way to describe iqta?

- A. A transferable fiscal-military assignment tied to service, administration and in-principle audit.
- B. A modern district with salaried bureaucracy only.
- C. A south Indian gold coin used in coastal trade.
- D. Absolute private ownership of land and peasants.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Iqta should be defined through claim, service and recall - not as private estate.

Learning MCQ 06

Question: Why must local administration be described cautiously?

- A. Because no local officials existed below the province.
- B. Because terms such as shiq, pargana, zamindar and qanungo do not have identical meaning or visibility across all Sultanate centuries.
- C. Because only Mughal sources discuss local society.
- D. Because villages were completely untouched by the state.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Chronology caution is essential in medieval administrative vocabulary.

Learning MCQ 07

Question: Which revenue statement is safest?

- A. Kharaj was only a symbolic tax and never a real burden.
- B. Firuz abolished all non-sharia fiscal categories everywhere permanently.
- C. Legal labels such as kharaj, jizya and zakat matter, but actual fiscal practice often merged, varied and depended on political circumstance.
- D. Jizya had the same practical meaning in every district from 1206 to 1526.

Answer: C.

Explanation: UPSC rewards the distinction between juristic vocabulary and working extraction.

Learning MCQ 08

Question: What drove Alauddin's dagh and chehra controls?

- A. A village self-government reform.
- B. A Lodi attempt to promote maritime trade.
- C. A project to spread paper currency.
- D. The need to supervise cavalry quality and salary claims within a military-fiscal system.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Horse branding and descriptive rolls belong to army control, not to Mughal-first mythology.

Learning MCQ 09

Question: What is the best reading of Sultanate justice?

- A. Sharia courts, royal regulations, kotwal policing and local custom coexisted in a plural and hierarchical order.
- B. Village panchayats disappeared entirely after 1206.
- C. Qazis governed non-Muslim communities in all matters without exception.
- D. Only one uniform civil code operated everywhere.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Judicial pluralism is one of Topic 07's safest high-value themes.

Learning MCQ 10

Question: Why is agrarian history central to Topic 07?

- A. Because military spending was independent of revenue and grain.
- B. Because peasant production and intermediary control financed the court, army and towns through surplus transfer.
- C. Because Sultanate economy was mainly based on overseas tribute only.
- D. Because towns had no relationship with villages.

Answer: B.

Explanation: A military-fiscal state cannot be explained without its agrarian base.

Learning MCQ 11

Question: How should monetisation be described?

- A. As irrelevant to trade because only gifts mattered.
- B. As paper money introduced permanently by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- C. As a real but uneven expansion of cash circuits, coin use and credit, not as a neat linear transition from barter to market modernity.
- D. As complete replacement of grain demand by cash in every region.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Tanka, jital, hundis and salary systems all matter, but unevenly.

Learning MCQ 12

Question: Which description of Sultanate urbanisation is safest?

- A. Every town was only a military cantonment with no commerce.
- B. The Sultanate had one single capital and no provincial cities.
- C. Urban growth ended long-distance trade.
- D. Towns grew through court demand, garrisons, trade, crafts and regional exchange, while still depending on rural surplus.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Urbanisation debate is strongest when tied to both demand and extraction.

Learning MCQ 13

Question: What is the best way to answer the 2023 technology PYQ?

- A. By linking devices and techniques to social effects on crafts, irrigation, construction, administration and hierarchy.
- B. By claiming all technology came fully formed from one foreign source.
- C. By listing inventions without saying who used them.
- D. By discussing only gunpowder and nothing else.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The question is social-history oriented, not a trivia list.

Learning MCQ 14

Question: How should Alauddin's market regulation be placed in the wider economy?

- A. As proof that ordinary markets ceased to exist forever.
- B. As an intense state intervention within a broader commercial world still run through merchants, banjaras, brokers and credit.
- C. As the beginning of a socialist planned economy.
- D. As a measure that removed all need for grain transport.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The market episode is important, but it should not swallow the whole economy.

Learning MCQ 15

Question: What is the safest description of Muslims as a social category under the Sultanate?

- A. Only foreign-born Muslims mattered in any occupation.
- B. The terms ashraf, ajlaf and arzal can be projected backward without caution.
- C. They were internally differentiated by ethnicity, status, occupation and origin; they were not one timeless homogeneous bloc.
- D. All Muslims formed a perfectly equal community from the outset.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Status language changed over time and must be used carefully.

Learning MCQ 16

Question: Which conversion statement is safest?

- A. Conversion happened only by the sword.
- B. No social or regional variation mattered.
- C. Conversion happened only by mystical preaching and never by politics.
- D. Conversion was multi-causal: patronage, mobility, local politics, devotional contact, frontier processes and belief all mattered in uneven ways.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This defeats the most common one-cause narratives.

Learning MCQ 17

Question: How should gender evidence be handled?

- A. By distinguishing elite prescription from practice and by noting class and regional variation in seclusion, property and ritual.
- B. By claiming women disappear entirely from the source record.
- C. By treating sati and jauhar as everyday universal institutions.
- D. By assuming all women everywhere observed the same purdah pattern.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The evidence is uneven, but not nonexistent; cautious layering is essential.

Learning MCQ 18

Question: What is the best closing line for a GS-I answer on Topic 07?

- A. The Sultanate economy was prosperous for every class in the same way.
- B. The Sultanate was centralising in aspiration, negotiated in practice, and socially uneven in effect.
- C. The Sultanate was either fully feudal or fully modern, with no middle ground.
- D. The Sultanate state can be understood entirely from one chronicle.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This verdict keeps institution, debate and social hierarchy together.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

Rotation check rule: This original broad-coverage sequence starts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C and D**.

Broad MCQ 01

Question: Which phrase most accurately describes the Delhi Sultanate?

- A. A society without villages or intermediaries.
- B. A timeless nation-state with fixed ministries.
- C. A Persianate military-fiscal state whose central claims depended on negotiation below.
- D. A purely spiritual caliphate run from Baghdad.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The best phrase joins ideology, coercion and agrarian mediation.

Broad MCQ 02

Question: Why is the phrase 'Persianate' useful in Topic 07?

- A. Because only Persian literature mattered in the Sultanate.
- B. Because all rulers were ethnically Persian.
- C. Because Persianate culture abolished local languages.
- D. Because it captures a transregional language-administrative culture that could include rulers and officials of varied origins.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The term is cultural-political, not ethnic.

Broad MCQ 03

Question: What made Delhi important beyond military conquest?

- A. Coinage, chancery, migrant scholars, court ritual and revenue coordination reinforced its centrality.
- B. It was the only town in north India.
- C. It mattered only after the Mughals.
- D. It had no link with monetisation.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Delhi became a nodal political and cultural centre, not just a fort.

Broad MCQ 04

Question: Which statement about succession under the Sultanate is safest?

- A. Village panchayats chose the sultan.
- B. Nomination, noble acceptance, military strength and household politics all shaped succession.
- C. Primogeniture operated without interruption.
- D. Caliphal appointment automatically settled succession.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This defeats simplistic dynastic assumptions.

Broad MCQ 05

Question: Why should Diwan-i-Risalat be handled cautiously?

- A. Because it was a Mughal-only innovation.
- B. Because the office certainly never existed.
- C. Because its exact portfolio is reconstructed differently by scholars and may shift across reigns.
- D. Because it only managed artillery.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Terminology caution itself is a mark of strong historical method.

Broad MCQ 06

Question: What was the political use of the barid network?

- A. It minted copper jitals.
- B. It managed Hindu temple endowments only.
- C. It replaced the military department entirely.
- D. It carried intelligence upward and helped rulers watch governors, nobles and markets.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Information was a technology of rule.

Broad MCQ 07

Question: Which social group is most directly linked to village headship in Topic 07's core evidence?

- A. Muqaddams and related local landed intermediaries.
- B. Caliphal envoys.
- C. Barids.
- D. Mir bakhshis.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Village headship belongs to local agrarian hierarchy.

Broad MCQ 08

Question: Why is iqta not equivalent to European feudalism?

- A. Because iqta had no connection at all with revenue.
- B. Because the Sultanate state's superior claim, transfer power and audit logic differ from a simple proprietary-vassal model.
- C. Because Europe had no cavalry.
- D. Because iqta was a maritime customs office.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The comparison is useful only when its limits are stated.

Broad MCQ 09

Question: What does khalisa most clearly indicate?

- A. A type of slave corps.
- B. A class of urban merchants.
- C. Revenue reserved for more direct crown collection and visibility.
- D. The village police post.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Khalisa is central to any discussion of Alauddin or crown finance.

Broad MCQ 10

Question: Which ruler most clearly combined price regulation with military horse inspection?

- A. Babur.
- B. Khizr Khan Sayyid.
- C. Raziya Sultan.
- D. Alauddin Khalji.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Daggh and chehra must be placed correctly.

Broad MCQ 11

Question: Which statement about Muhammad bin Tughlaq is safest for Topic 07?

- A. He pushed centralisation, cash demand and recruitment widening further than his predecessors, but strained compliance and trust.
- B. He abolished monetisation.
- C. He ruled only Delhi and Palam.
- D. He had no interest in caliphal legitimacy.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The strongest line explains ambition and breakdown together.

Broad MCQ 12

Question: Why does Firuz matter in Topic 07?

- A. He abandoned public works entirely.
- B. He softened audit, encouraged heredity, expanded canals and workshops, and sharpened some juristic markers such as separate jizya.
- C. He removed all slave institutions.
- D. He invented the iqta from nothing.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Firuz's regime altered both welfare and hierarchy.

Broad MCQ 13

Question: What is the safest reading of jizya under the Sultanate?

- A. It was absent from all Sultanate history.
- B. It was always completely separate from land demand from the first day.
- C. It mattered politically and symbolically, but it should not stand in for the totality of Hindu-Muslim social relations.
- D. It proves that all policy was only religious.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The tax has to be placed in a broader fiscal and political field.

Broad MCQ 14

Question: What best explains the growth of hundis?

- A. The replacement of silver coins by cowries in Delhi.
- B. A ban on merchant initiative.
- C. The end of road travel.
- D. Long-distance trade, credit needs and the work of money-changers and financiers across regions.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Hundis belong to commercial and financial integration.

Broad MCQ 15

Question: Which commodity cluster best captures long-distance Sultanate trade?

- A. Textiles outward; horses, high-grade cloth and select goods inward.
- B. Only war booty outward and nothing inward.
- C. Only rice and wheat outward from every region.
- D. Only temple icons and paper outward.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Textiles remained India's most important manufacturing strength.

Broad MCQ 16

Question: What is the safest claim about artisans under the Sultanate?

- A. They were all village serfs with no urban presence.
- B. They worked in towns and villages, in independent settings and in state-linked workshops, under unequal social conditions.
- C. They disappeared after market regulation.
- D. They were all state slaves.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Craft life was varied and often poorly documented.

Broad MCQ 17

Question: How should the spinning wheel be used in an answer?

- A. As proof that every household became prosperous.
- B. As a guaranteed twelfth-century Indian invention with exact first date.
- C. As evidence of technological diffusion and textile efficiency, with chronology caution and social-effect analysis.
- D. As irrelevant to cloth production.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Technology claims need both mechanism and caution.

Broad MCQ 18

Question: Why is the term 'urban revolution' debated?

- A. Because only European trade created Indian towns.
- B. Because no towns existed at all.
- C. Because the debate concerns only architecture.
- D. Because town growth, crafts and monetisation were real, yet they rested on coercive extraction and uneven benefit.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is one of Topic 07's major historiographical axes.

Broad MCQ 19

Question: What is the safest interpretation of ashraf-ajlaf language?

- A. It signals social differentiation within Muslim society, but its use needs chronology and source caution.
- B. It is a fixed fourteenth-century bureaucratic census category everywhere.
- C. It replaces all regional and occupational distinctions.
- D. It proves perfect class equality among Muslims.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The labels are real and useful, but not timeless.

Broad MCQ 20

Question: Which statement best captures the position of Hindus under the Sultanate?

- A. No Hindu served any state function.
- B. They were not simply excluded: chiefs, peasants, merchants, soldiers, accountants and managers all remained important, amid conflict and hierarchy.
- C. All Hindus were treated identically across all reigns.
- D. Hindu society vanished from the countryside.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The strongest answer combines cooperation and coercion.

Broad MCQ 21

Question: Why is conversion a poor master-explanation for Sultanate society?

- A. Because conversions never happened.
- B. Because only rulers converted.
- C. Because social history also turns on landed power, towns, labour, language, courts, trade and everyday negotiation.
- D. Because conversions alone explain every town and market.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Conversion matters, but it is not the only explanatory engine.

Broad MCQ 22

Question: What is the best distinction between bandagan and wider slavery?

- A. Bandagan were Mughal revenue clerks.
- B. Bandagan were identical to all slaves in law and social effect.
- C. Bandagan were simply village tenants.
- D. Bandagan were elite household military slaves with training and office prospects, unlike most domestic or captive slaves.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is a crucial conceptual distinction in Topic 07.

Broad MCQ 23

Question: How should purdah be described?

- A. As a stronger upper-class and courtly norm that spread unevenly; not as a universal practice for all women in all regions.
- B. As a Sultanate law imposed successfully on everyone.
- C. As absent from all medieval India.
- D. As identical among every caste and class.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Gender answers need class and region built in.

Broad MCQ 24

Question: Which statement about education is safest?

- A. Paper-making ended manuscript culture.
- B. Maktabas, madrasas, mosques, khanqahs, Sanskrit learning and practical multilingualism coexisted.
- C. Persian replaced every other language immediately.
- D. Only royal princes were educated.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Knowledge institutions were multiple, not singular.

Broad MCQ 25

Question: Why are Persian-knowing Hindus important for Topic 07?

- A. They prove caste disappeared.
- B. They were only nineteenth-century phenomena.
- C. They show that administrative culture could expand across community lines without erasing hierarchy.
- D. They prove Persian ceased to dominate administration.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Language competence created new service niches.

Broad MCQ 26

Question: Which statement about Sufis in Topic 07 is safest?

- A. Sufis alone ran Sultanate law courts.
- B. All Sufis were anti-state in every setting.
- C. Topic 07 must ignore Sufis completely.
- D. They matter here mainly as part of social interaction and political context, while full movement ownership belongs to Topic 10.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Boundary discipline is part of a strong package.

Broad MCQ 27

Question: How should temple destruction and patronage be framed in Topic 07?

- A. Episodes must be placed in political, military and local context rather than being flattened into a single civilisational formula.
- B. Every temple was always protected.
- C. Every temple was always destroyed.
- D. The issue is irrelevant to social history.

Answer: A.

Explanation: This avoids communal simplification while remaining evidence-led.

Broad MCQ 28

Question: What is the strongest way to read Barani?

- A. As a perfectly neutral census reporter.
- B. As indispensable for elite ideology and policy language, but shaped by aristocratic prejudice and normative aims.
- C. As useless because he was biased.
- D. As the only source that matters.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Good answers use Barani critically, not blindly.

Broad MCQ 29

Question: Why are coins valuable in Topic 07?

- A. They show that all provinces used one fixed economy at all times.
- B. They reveal precise peasant income.
- C. They connect sovereignty, minting, monetisation and public claims without proving complete territorial control.
- D. They replace the need for all written sources.

Answer: C.

Explanation: Coins are strong but bounded evidence.

Broad MCQ 30

Question: Which statement about qanungo is safest?

- A. It is the normal office for every Mamluk village.
- B. It replaced the kotwal.
- C. It was another name for the ariz.
- D. Use the term only with chronology caution; it is not a secure universal office for the early Sultanate local hierarchy.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Administrative vocabulary must be time-bound.

Broad MCQ 31

Question: What best captures Lodi politics from a Topic 07 perspective?

- A. Afghan claims of consultation and equality complicated but did not abolish monarchy or centralisation.
- B. The Lodis ruled only through Sufi shrines.
- C. The Lodis rejected all revenue supervision.
- D. The Lodis ended all iqta-like assignment structures overnight.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The Afghan angle is about elite bargaining, not statelessness.

Broad MCQ 32

Question: What is the safest one-line verdict on Sultanate society?

- A. It was a static Hindu-Muslim binary with no shared spaces.
- B. It was stratified, interactive and changing - never socially flat, never wholly segregated, never fully equal.
- C. It can be reconstructed perfectly from one chronicle.
- D. It was a casteless commercial utopia.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This verdict is short, balanced and high-yield.

Remedial trap MCQs

Rotation check rule: This remedial sequence restarts at **A** and rotates strictly through **B, C and D**.

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which mistake most distorts Topic 07?

- A. Noting that departmental functions evolved.
- B. Using chronology caution in local vocabulary.
- C. Treating one ruler's office-chart as the permanent bureaucracy of the whole Sultanate.
- D. Separating caliphal idiom from effective sovereignty.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The topic demands variation across Mamluk, Khalji, Tughlaq and Lodi phases.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: Which description of iqta is wrong?

- A. A service-linked assignment.
- B. A mechanism that tied revenue to military obligation.
- C. A tract whose holder could be transferred.
- D. A permanent private estate freely inheritable without superior state claim.

Answer: D.

Explanation: This is the core remedial distinction.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: What is the safest comparison with the Mughal jagir?

- A. There is family resemblance in transferable revenue assignment, but no full equivalence in procedure, service scale or chronology.
- B. Iqta had no link at all to military service.
- C. Jagir existed unchanged before the Sultanate.

- D. Iqta and jagir were identical in every respect.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Comparison helps only when differences are preserved.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which statement is unsafe on state and religion?

- A. Sharia mattered to legitimation and some offices.
- B. The Sultanate can be labelled simply a timeless theocracy without discussing zawabit, expediency or political limits.
- C. Ulema-state relations varied by ruler.
- D. Rulers also issued state regulations.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The strongest answer refuses one-word labels.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: What is the correct approach to conversion?

- A. Explain everything through force alone.
- B. Assume every region changed identically.
- C. Reject one-cause narratives and map multiple local processes.
- D. Explain everything through saintly preaching alone.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This is a recurring UPSC trap in medieval history.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which statement about social categories is safest?

- A. They erase ethnic and occupational differences.
- B. They can replace all local evidence.
- C. They are timeless democratic self-descriptions.
- D. Terms like ashraf and ajlaf are useful only with chronology, source and status caution.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Never force later or broader categories as rigid census blocks.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: How should technology transfer be framed?

- A. As diffusion and adaptation through local artisans, state demand and regional conditions - not as one-way civilising import.
- B. As a topic unrelated to society.
- C. As proof that Indians had no prior craft skill.
- D. As immediate uniform adoption everywhere.

Answer: A.

Explanation: UPSC prefers mechanism and adaptation over civilisational cliché.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: What is wrong with describing towns as only military camps?

- A. It notes court demand in urban growth.
- B. It ignores textile production, merchant finance, administrative clerks, religious institutions and regional trade.
- C. It links towns to roads and sarais.
- D. It recognises that some towns began near garrisons.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Many towns were mixed military, administrative and commercial spaces.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: What is the safest reading of slavery?

- A. Slavery ended after the Mamluks.
- B. Slavery was socially harmless because masters fed slaves.
- C. Multiple forms existed, and slavery depressed free labour status even when some elite slaves rose high.
- D. Only military slavery mattered.

Answer: C.

Explanation: This restores social history to the institution.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which statement about Hindus under the Sultanate is most misleading?

- A. Conflict and accommodation coexisted.
- B. Local machinery often remained in Hindu hands.
- C. Upper-caste restrictions also shaped interaction.
- D. That they were uniformly excluded from administration, trade and military activity.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The simplest exclusion formula is historically unsafe.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: How should under-80-word evidence boxes in answers be handled?

- A. Use them as concise synthesis only when anchored in a larger argument with named evidence.
- B. Avoid evidence because it complicates the narrative.
- C. Write only verdicts and no mechanism.
- D. Replace the whole answer with one slogan.

Answer: A.

Explanation: This reinforces answer architecture discipline.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which closing judgement is best?

- A. It can be summarised entirely by one tax term.
- B. The Sultanate combined centralising aspiration, negotiated enforcement and socially uneven outcomes.
- C. It was fully modern or fully feudal with no middle ground.
- D. It changed nothing socially or economically.

Answer: B.

Explanation: This sentence recovers the whole topic in one line.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified and honestly-adjacent PYQs

Direct PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2019 (directly relevant; exact wording verified locally)

Question: Consider the following statements:

1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the in-charge of revenue collection was known as "Amil".
2. The Iqta system of Sultans of Delhi was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of "Mir Bakshi" came into existence during the reign of Khalji Sultans of Delhi.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 only B. 1 and 2 only C. 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 1 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is correct because *amil* was the revenue-collection functionary at the relevant level. Statement 2 is incorrect because iqta had West and Central Asian antecedents before its Indian adaptation. Statement 3 is incorrect because *Mir Bakshi* belongs to the Mughal system; the Sultanate military department centred on the ariz and Diwan-i-Arz.

Why this earns marks: It tests statement-by-statement institutional placement and blocks both the indigenous-iqta myth and the Mughal-office projection trap.

Demand decoding: Treat "Consider the following statements: 1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the..." as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For "Consider the following statements: 1. In the revenue administration of Delhi Sultanate, the...", add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Adjacent PYQ 02 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (directly relevant source-method question; wording preserved in repository)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for medieval India because they preserve the language of sovereignty, conquest, justice, bureaucracy and courtly aspiration. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only when read through **genre, patronage and silence**.

For Topic 07 this is especially clear. Barani helps explain kingship, aristocratic prejudice, Alauddin's market measures and the tension between sharia and political expediency, but he is late, moralising and hostile to low-born advancement. Ibn Battuta illuminates roads, towns, gifts, punishments and products, yet his traveller's eye seeks the vivid rather than the statistically ordinary. Afif and Firuz's own *Futuhat* reveal how a ruler wished benevolence and piety to be seen. Coins, inscriptions and buildings in turn provide harder public claims, but not full social life.

Thus Persian sources do reflect the age - especially its elite political culture, administrative ambition and moral vocabulary - but not as neutral mirrors. They require comparison with material evidence, local structures and non-courtly social realities.

Why this earns marks: It comments on the word 'reflect' itself, names multiple source types and turns source bias into method rather than complaint.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on "Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...)"; coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer...)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Adjacent PYQ 03 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2022 (adjacent but useful frontier-institution question; exact wording verified locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

Inferred answer - not officially verified locally: 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure predates Jalaluddin Khalji. Statement 2 is correct because a major Mongol assault reached and besieged Delhi in Alauddin's time. Statement 3 is not secure in the form stated.

Why this earns marks: It is adjacent rather than core, but it sharpens the army-frontier chronology that any Topic 07 answer on cavalry finance and defence must keep straight.

Demand decoding: Treat “With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol...” as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements: 1. The first Mongol...”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

Direct PYQ 04 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (directly relevant; wording preserved in repository)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period witnessed important technological diffusion in textiles, record-keeping, irrigation, construction and military equipment. Their significance lay less in isolated invention than in **how they reshaped production, urban growth and state capacity.**

Paper-making widened the practical world of accounts, letters and manuscripts. The spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow and improved looms strengthened textile production. Water-lifting devices and, in some regions, canal networks supported cultivation. Lime mortar, arches and domes enlarged the scale and durability of construction. Saddles, armour, stirrups and horse-management techniques mattered to cavalry warfare.

Social effect was uneven. Urban workshops, state offices, merchants and military systems benefited most. Artisans found new demand, but hierarchy persisted and slavery or low-wage labour remained embedded in production. Irrigation and construction enhanced elite and state power more than universal welfare.

Thus technological change under the Sultanate contributed to urbanisation, stronger administration, wider textile production and military organisation, while remaining filtered through social inequality.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts, moves from devices to effects and avoids the trap of a bare technology list.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ verification ledger and scope honesty

- **Directly routed and solved:** 2019 Prelims revenue administration and 2023 GS-I Sultanate technology.
Adjacent: 2020 GS-I Persian sources belongs to Topic 24.
- **Directly verified but honestly adjacent:** 2022 Prelims GS-I Mongol chronology question.
- **Routed but exact wording not locally recoverable in the available paper set:** 2022 Prelims GS-I Q52 on *fanam* medieval monetary terminology. Topic 07 covers the demand honestly in the learning sections and in the register notes, but does not invent an unverified official stem.
- No coaching-studio question and no optional-paper question has been relabelled as a UPSC PYQ.

Original solved Mains questions

Mains 01 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on negotiated local power. Answer in 150 words.

Model answer:

The Delhi Sultanate built a visible central apex: the sultan distributed office and iqta, commanded the army, issued coinage, controlled chancery communication and projected justice. Departments such as the Wizarat, Arz and Insha show that rule had differentiated institutional form. Coins, khutba and court ceremonial further publicised sovereignty.

Yet this apex never operated in a social vacuum. Muqtis, amils, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhuris, patwaris, chiefs and merchants translated central claims into actual grain, cash, horses and obedience. Village structures were not erased; they were used. Even when Alauddin tightened khalisa control, he did not abolish local intermediaries. Firuz later softened audit and hereditary claims widened.

Thus the best formulation is that the Sultanate was centralised in aspiration and more centralised than many earlier regional monarchies, but it remained negotiated in implementation. Distance, ecology, faction and local landed strength limited uniform bureaucratic control.

Why this earns marks: It opens with a direct thesis, names institutions, explains the local mechanism, adds dynastic variation and ends with a balanced verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a

graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Explain why the Delhi Sultanate is best described as a centralised apex resting on...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 02 - 10 marks

Question: How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property? Answer in 150 words.

Model answer:

The iqta was a fiscal-military assignment through which the sultan transferred the right to collect revenue from a tract to a muqti or wali in return for service, administration and troop maintenance. The holder preserved order, met authorised expenses and, in principle, remained accountable for the balance due to the centre. Transfer, recall and audit were the key checks.

It should not be treated as private property because legal superiority remained with the state. The muqti did not own the soil, all peasants, or an automatically hereditary estate. Procedures differed across time: Mamluk rulers used iqta for consolidation, Alauddin tightened supervision in the core, Muhammad bin Tughlaq experimented with cash and revenue farming, and Firuz encouraged heredity and softer audit.

Therefore the iqta was a service-linked revenue assignment whose meaning changed with political strength. Calling it simple property, or equating it mechanically with European feudalism or Mughal jagir, obscures its historical function.

Why this earns marks: It defines the institution, shows mechanism, inserts chronology and blocks the standard property trap.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property?...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “How did the iqta system function, and why should it not be equated with private property?...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 03 - 15 marks

Question: Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under the Delhi Sultanate. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The Delhi Sultanate's towns did not float free from the countryside. Monetisation and urbanisation expanded, but they did so through a military-fiscal system that drew agrarian surplus upward.

First, stable coinage - especially the silver tanka and copper jital - helped taxation, salary payment and market exchange. Second, a stronger central state improved roads, relays and sarais, allowing grain, cloth, horses and money to move between regions. Third, merchant finance through hundis, modis and sarrafs widened the reach of long-distance trade. Delhi, Lahore, Multan, Lakhnauti, Cambay and Sonargaon all grew through this interaction of state demand and commerce.

But the urban story cannot be separated from rural burden. Alauddin's core-zone extraction, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's harsh doab assessment and the dependence of iqta-holders on rural realisation show that towns and armies were sustained by peasant production. Khuts, muqaddams and chiefs mediated this transfer and often protected their own position.

Hence growth and coercion must be read together. Urban revival was real - textiles, paper, metallurgy and trade flourished - yet much of that revival depended on unequal surplus extraction and elite consumption.

Why this earns marks: It links coinage, roads, finance and towns to the agrarian mechanism instead of narrating them separately.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Examine the relationship between monetisation, urbanisation and agrarian extraction under...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 04 - 15 marks

Question: Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The Sultanate nobility changed from an early concentration of Turks and military slaves to a wider, more contested elite including Persians, Khaljis, Afghans, Indian Muslims, converts and local allies. That widening mattered politically because it altered both opportunity and instability.

In the Mamluk phase, elite slavery and Turkish high-status claims gave the court a disciplined but narrow ruling circle. Barani's later contempt for low-born appointment reflects this older exclusionary ideal. Yet even early Delhi required Tajik administrators, Hindu accountants and local chiefs.

The Khalji phase widened access to office by weakening old Turkish monopoly. Alauddin's state needed talent and force more than pedigree alone. Muhammad bin Tughlaq widened recruitment further, appointing foreigners, new men and some Hindus to high office. This improved reach, but chroniclers portray intense aristocratic resentment. Firuz reversed course toward conciliation, high salaries and heredity, which reduced friction in the short run but narrowed discipline and hardened oligarchic interests. In the Lodi phase, Afghan notions of consultation complicated monarchical centralisation further.

Therefore, changing noble composition was not a background detail. It shaped succession, military command, revenue control and ideological conflict at the heart of the Sultanate.

Why this earns marks: It uses chronology, named source bias and political consequence rather than listing communities mechanically.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences....”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess the changing composition of the Sultanate nobility and its political consequences....”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 05 - 20 marks

Question: 'The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.' Discuss. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

The statement is persuasive because it rejects two misleading simplifications at once. The Delhi Sultanate did develop differentiated institutions, but these never produced a uniform modern-style bureaucracy across all regions and reigns. Likewise, Islamic language and law mattered deeply, yet the state cannot be reduced to a timeless theocracy.

On the administrative side, the Sultanate had a clear central apex: the sultan, wazir, ariz, insha, qazi-sadr and barid network. Coinage, khutba, court ceremonial and iqta transfers demonstrate organised sovereignty. Yet implementation depended on muqtis, amils, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhuris, chiefs, merchants and village accountants. Terms such as shiq, pargana and zamindar must themselves be used chronologically and regionally. Alauddin's tighter supervision, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's over-centralising experiments, Firuz's hereditary drift and Lodi Afghan bargaining show that no single administrative diagram fits the whole period.

On the religious side, rulers invoked sharia, appointed qazis and ulema, and used caliphal or juristic idiom. But political expediency repeatedly supplemented formal law. Alauddin openly asserted reason of state; Muhammad bin Tughlaq mixed symbolic caliphal legitimacy with wider intellectual contact; Firuz moved toward sharper juristic display yet still governed through public works, compromise and material calculation. Non-Muslim communities retained their own social institutions and local law in many settings.

Thus the Sultanate is best read as a Persianate military-fiscal monarchy using Islamic legitimacy while ruling through negotiated, uneven and practical governance.

Why this earns marks: It answers both negations directly, organises the body into state and religion, and ends with a precise synthetic verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.'...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "The Delhi Sultanate was neither a uniform bureaucracy nor a timeless Islamic state.'...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 06 - 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy under the Delhi Sultanate. Answer in 250 words.

Model answer:

Technology diffusion and trade growth under the Delhi Sultanate reshaped production and exchange, but their social effects were filtered through hierarchy. Gains were real, yet unevenly distributed.

In production, wider use of the spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow, improved looms, paper-making and construction techniques supported textiles, record-keeping and urban building. Water-lifting improvements and canals aided cultivation in some regions. Better roads, sarais and monetary circulation widened long-distance exchange. Merchant groups - Multanis, Gujaratis, Khurasanis, Marwaris, Jains and Bohras - worked with financiers and hundis to move goods and credit.

These processes encouraged urbanisation and specialised craft activity. Delhi, Cambay, Sonargaon and other towns became centres of demand and exchange. Court consumption, army provisioning and merchant trade stimulated artisans in both towns and villages.

Yet the social gains were not equal. Peasants still bore heavy revenue pressure. Artisans often worked for low wages or in dependent conditions. Slavery - domestic, artisanal and military - remained embedded in elite society, and the use of slaves could depress the status of free labour. Upper-status prejudice persisted among both Hindu and Muslim elites; purdah and social restriction spread most strongly among the upper classes.

Therefore technology and trade expanded capability, but they did not democratise society. They enlarged state power, urban consumption and commercial reach within a deeply stratified order.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on “Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows the directive, links precise evidence to analysis, acknowledges source or regional limits and closes with a reasoned verdict.

How to improve this answer: For “Evaluate the social consequences of technology diffusion, trade growth and labour hierarchy...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Administration, Economy & Society under the Sultanate - ADVANCED

Subject: History (Medieval India) · **Tier:** Advanced (deeper understanding) · **GS Paper:** GS-I (also Prelims).
Grounded in: Satish Chandra, *Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals - Part I (Delhi Sultanat, 1206-1526)* - chapters “Economic and Social Life in North India” and sections on Sultanate administration, revenue, nobility, trade and towns. **FACT:** = from source book · **ANALYSIS:** = inference / standard knowledge · **CURRENT:** = current affairs.
Companion: basic/07_Sultanate-Administration-Economy-Society.md. *Chronology spine:* 00_Master-Chronology.md.

Mini-timeline

Date	Event
FACT: 1206	Sultanate begins; early Turks depend on existing local chiefs and revenue practices
FACT: 13th century	Iqta system, Turkish nobility and central departments develop
FACT: 1296-1316	Alauddin intervenes deeply in revenue, markets and army organisation
FACT: 1320s	Ghiyasuddin moderates revenue policy and returns toward sharing in khalisa areas
FACT: 1325-51	Muhammad bin Tughlaq expands centralisation, cash revenue, salaries and administrative experiments
FACT: 1351-88	Firuz encourages canals, orchards, karkhanas, slaves and high noble salaries
FACT: Early 15th century	Break-up of Delhi slows the trend towards new landed gentry and centralised surplus extraction

1. Snapshot & core idea

Deeper - revenue, iqta and the rural order.

FACT: Sultanate administration did not abolish older rural society; it superimposed central claims over chiefs, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhris, patwaris and village communities.

- FACT: Early Turkish rulers largely left land-revenue collection to Hindu chiefs and existing arrangements; deeper intervention came mainly from Alauddin Khalji onward.
- FACT: Alauddin's half-share demand, measurement and khalisa expansion were a massive intervention against privileged village groups; Muhammad bin Tughlaq tried to revive/extend such control, but harsh officials and artificial assessment triggered rebellion.
- FACT: Ghiyasuddin replaced measurement by sharing in khalisa areas, reducing cultivator risk when crops failed.
- FACT: Firuz's canals improved cultivation in Haryana and the doab; benefits, however, flowed strongly to nobles and rural privileged groups because much revenue had been assigned as iqtas.
- FACT: The term **zamindar** begins to appear by the early fourteenth century for hereditary intermediaries and later widens under the Mughals.
- FACT: Iqta control rested on transfer, audit and the distinction between authorised expenditure and surplus due to the centre; practice varied with the strength of the sultan and distance from Delhi.

Deeper - monetisation, urbanisation and social hierarchy.

FACT: The Sultanate saw a growing money economy: cash revenue, silver tanka, large salaries, merchant finance and long-distance trade tied the countryside to towns.

- FACT: Multanis and Sahs financed nobles; later the centralised revenue system increased liquid resources in elite hands.
- FACT: Indian textiles formed the core of production: coarse cloth, calico, muslin, zardozi, painted/printed cloth, Gujarat patolas and Bengal fine cotton/silk.
- FACT: Technologies popularised or expanded included spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow, improved loom, paper-making, lime mortar, iron stirrup, armour and metallurgical production.
- FACT: Towns were not isolated from villages: artisans worked in both, and specialised craft villages/towns existed in Gujarat and south India.
- FACT: Society was sharply stratified: nobles and merchants accumulated wealth, while peasants, artisans, labourers, domestic servants and slaves lived with insecurity and low wages.

2. Key classification / data

Sector	Advanced features	Why it matters
FACT: Revenue	Khalisa, iqta, measurement, sharing, cash commutation	Centralisation of rural surplus
FACT: Rural elites	Rais, rawats, khuts, muqaddams, chaudhris, zamindars	Local power mediated Sultanate control
FACT: Administration	Wazir, ariz, barids, amils, mushrif/mustaufi, kotwal	Bureaucratic expansion and surveillance
FACT: Nobility	Turks, Afghans, Iranians, Indian Muslims; high salaries	Elite politics and surplus consumption
FACT: Trade finance	Multanis, Sahs, hundis, brokers/dallals	Growth of credit and commerce
FACT: Textiles	Muslin, calico, patola, zardozi, block printing	India's main manufacturing strength
FACT: Karkhanas	Royal workshops employing artisans/slaves	Luxury production and state demand
FACT: Towns	Delhi, Daulatabad, Multan, Lahore, Kara, Lakhnauti, Khambayat	Urban revival under centralised rule
FACT: Social life	Purdah, caste rigidity, Hindu-Muslim interaction, slavery	Stratified but interactive society

Terminology caution: Satish Chandra associates *diwan-i-risalat* with religious matters and grants; other scholarly reconstructions have assigned it diplomatic functions. State the source used rather than presenting a debated portfolio as universally settled.

3. Study links

Study link: FACT: Alauddin's revenue-market machine -> advanced/04_Khaljis-Alauddin.md. **Study link:** FACT: Muhammad and Firuz revenue/canal policies -> advanced/05_Tughlaqs.md. **Study link:** ANALYSIS: Trade and textile networks -> link forward to Portuguese entry and Indian Ocean commerce.

4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)

- FACT: Traditional pre-Sultanate cesses included **bhaga**, **bhog** and **kar**.
- FACT: Alauddin raised land revenue to half in the upper doab and made areas **khalisa**.
- FACT: Ghiyasuddin favoured sharing over measurement in khalisa areas.
- FACT: Muhammad bin Tughlaq used standard yields and official prices, causing heavier incidence.
- FACT: Firuz's canals supported two crops and carried a 10% water charge (**haqq-i-sharb**).
- FACT: **Hundis** financed long-distance trade and money transfer.
- FACT: The spinning wheel's wider use increased spinner efficiency; cotton-carder's bow speeded cleaning cotton.
- FACT: Delhi and Daulatabad were major towns; Khambayat/Cambay was a major textile and maritime centre.
- FACT: Slaves were acquired in war; Firuz collected about 1,80,000 and trained 12,000 as artisans.

5. UPSC Traps

MEMORY: Trap: Sultanate economy was neither static nor uniformly prosperous; growth, monetisation and inequality advanced together.

- **WRONG:** Villages were fully autonomous and untouched. -> From Alauddin onward, state intervention in measurement, revenue and intermediaries increased.
- **WRONG:** Town crafts were separate from rural crafts. -> Satish Chandra stresses overlap and mobility between towns and specialised villages.
- **WRONG:** Muslim society was socially homogeneous. -> Turks, Iranians, Afghans and Indian Muslims maintained ethnic/racial distinctions.
- **WRONG:** Conversion happened mainly by sword. -> Source stresses political, social, regional and economic factors, with limited evidence for mass forced conversion.
- **WRONG:** Slavery was only domestic and harmless. -> It was degrading, depressed free labour status, and sometimes fed karkhanas/bodyguards.

6. CURRENT: Current link

CURRENT: Current linkage (verify live before use): Maritime-heritage policy can provide a present hook for Cambay/Khambayat, textiles and merchant credit. Use a dated conclave or ministry initiative only after checking the official release.

7. Mains angles

- **ANALYSIS:** Sultanate administration should be analysed as a layered system: central departments, iqta assignments and local intermediaries.
- **ANALYSIS:** Monetisation under the Sultanate linked revenue extraction, elite salaries, merchant credit and urban craft demand.
- **ANALYSIS:** Social history of the Sultanate needs a balanced frame: conflict and hierarchy existed, but so did administrative, commercial and cultural interaction.

□ Concept: India as an industrial hub before European dominance

ANALYSIS: Use the advanced trade material to challenge colonial-era assumptions: Indian textiles and merchant networks were strong before Portuguese intrusion, and India functioned as a manufacturing hub between West Asia and Southeast Asia.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2023	GS-I	12	Technological changes of the Sultanate period and Indian society	What were and How did · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Technological changes of the Sultanate period and Indian society

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Final consolidated register notes

Register Module 01 - Chronology and ownership spine

- Topic 07 covers Sultanate institutions across Mamluk, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid and Lodi phases.
- Topic 03-06 own political narrative in depth; Topic 07 owns the thematic synthesis.
- Best timeline anchors: Iltutmish consolidation -> Balban kingship -> Alauddin military-fiscal tightening -> Muhammad bin Tughlaq's overreach -> Firuz's heredity and canals -> Lodi bargaining and transition.
- Use chronology to show change, not to turn the answer into a dynasty list.

Register Module 02 - State formation formula

- Conquest created nodal control; it did not automatically create countryside rule.
- Persianate court forms gave ideological and administrative language.
- Local chiefs, khuts, muqaddams, accountants and merchants made rule workable.
- Best phrase: **central military-fiscal apex resting on negotiated local power.**

Register Module 03 - Kingship and legitimacy

- Sultan = military commander, distributor of office and source of high justice.
- Khutba and sikka signalled sovereignty.
- Caliphal recognition enhanced standing; it did not create power.
- Sharia mattered, but rulers repeatedly used political expediency and regulations.
- Avoid both 'modern secularism' and 'timeless theocracy'.

Register Module 04 - Offices and departments

Office	Core meaning	Caution
Wazir	Finance and oversight	Weight varied by ruler
Ariz / Diwan-i-Arz	Muster, equipment, pay	Sultan remained commander-in-chief
Diwan-i-Insha	Chancery and correspondence	Documentary survival uneven
Diwan-i-Risalat	Often religious grants in this source base	Portfolio debated
Sadr / qazi / muhtasib / barid	Grants, justice, moral policing, intelligence	Best evidenced in stronger centres

Register Module 05 - Nobility and bandagan

- Elite = Turks, Tajiks/Persians, Khaljis, Afghans, Indian Muslims, converts, ulema and local allies.
- Barani-style prejudice matters as evidence of status anxiety.
- Bandagan = elite military-household slavery with training and possible manumission.
- Distinguish this from domestic or artisanal slavery.

Register Module 06 - Iqta essentials

- Iqta = assignment, not simple private property.
- Muqti / wali collected revenue, maintained order and in principle answered to the centre.
- Transfer, recall and audit mattered when rulers were strong.
- Khalji tightening and Firuz's heredity changed iqta's political meaning.
- Compare with jagir carefully; do not equate automatically.

Register Module 07 - Provincial and local administration

- Shiq and pargana language requires chronology caution.
- Amil, chaudhuri, khuts, muqaddams and patwari are high-yield terms.
- Qanungo is safer in later contexts; do not project everywhere backward.
- Zamindar broadens over time; use cautiously.

Register Module 08 - Revenue, army and law

- Fiscal language: kharaj, jizya, zakat, ushr, khams, customs, cesses.
- Practice often diverged from formal category.
- Dag and chehra belong to cavalry supervision, not to Mughal invention.
- Kotwal, qazi, muhtasib and local custom formed a plural legal world.
- Numbers are less useful than mechanism and hierarchy.

Register Module 09 - Agrarian base and surplus transfer

- Main crops: rice, sugarcane, wheat, oilseeds, sesame, indigo, cotton.
- Irrigation: wells, bunds, tanks, later canals under Firuz.
- Peasant burden worked through intermediaries; village elites could shift costs downward.
- Urban and military growth rested on agrarian transfer.

Register Module 10 - Currency, towns, trade and technology

- Silver tanka + copper jital = core coinage language.
- Monetisation was real but uneven.
- Important towns: Delhi, Lahore, Multan, Lakhnauti, Cambay, Sonargaon, Daulatabad.
- Textiles led trade; horses were crucial imports.
- Paper-making, spinning wheel, cotton-carder's bow, rahat, lime mortar, arch and dome are the high-yield technology cluster.

Register Module 11 - Society, conversion, slavery and gender

- Muslim society was internally stratified; *ashraf-ajlaf* language needs caution.
- Hindus remained vital to local administration, trade and landed society.
- Conversion was multi-causal, not one-cause.
- Slavery had multiple forms; elite military slavery was only one of them.
- Purdah, sati and jauhar require class and evidence caution.

Register Module 12 - Education, language and interaction

- Maktabas, madrasas, mosques, khanqahs and Sanskrit learning coexisted.
- Persian dominated administration; Arabic retained scholarly prestige.
- Hindavi and regional languages mattered in everyday contact and later literature.
- Persian-knowing Hindus show administrative widening without social equality.

Register Module 13 - Historiography and answer language

- Better than 'fully centralised': **centralising but unevenly realised**.
- Better than 'feudal': **service-linked revenue assignment with limited analogy**.
- Better than 'urban revolution' alone: **urban growth plus coercive extraction**.
- Better than 'Islamic state' alone: **sharia, zawabit and expediency in changing balance**.
- Best answer pattern: **claim -> named evidence -> mechanism -> limitation -> verdict**.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Sultanate thematic chronology

13th c. -> consolidation through court, iqta and inherited local structures
1296-1316 -> Alauddin tightens revenue, cavalry and market supervision
1320s-1351 -> sharing, assessment, cash demands and high-risk experiments
1351-1388 -> canals, karkhanas, elite conciliation and hereditary drift
15th c. -> weaker Delhi control and stronger regional landed interests
RULE: institutions changed by reign, region, distance and enforcement capacity.
MUST REMEMBER: Iqta, muqti, kharaj, jizya and central diwans must be matched to their precise fiscal-administrative functions.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: State formation as a layered network

SULTAN / COURT -> sovereignty, appointments, campaign direction
CENTRAL DEPARTMENTS -> finance, army, correspondence and intelligence
IQTADARS / GOVERNORS -> troops, collection and provincial bargaining
KHUTS / MUQADDAMS / CHIEFS -> village access, information and mediation
CULTIVATORS / ARTISANS -> production, labour and taxable surplus
VERDICT: coercive at nodes, negotiated across the countryside.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Central departments with chronology caution

WIZARAT / WAZIR -> finance, accounts and revenue supervision
ARZ / ARIZ-I MAMALIK -> muster, horses, equipment and pay
INSHA -> royal correspondence and chancery
RISALAT -> religious-grant or diplomatic portfolio is historiographically debated
SADR / QAZI -> grants, learned authority and judicial functions
BARID -> intelligence, reports and communication
RULE: office names, portfolios and practical power changed by reign.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Iqta fiscal-military flow

CROWN ASSIGNS REVENUE CLAIM -> MUQTI / IQTADAR COLLECTS
|
authorised salary + troops + local administration
|
accounts and audit -> surplus expected for the centre
|
transfer restrains local roots; weak control encourages heredity
RULE: assignment of revenue was not unrestricted ownership of land.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Revenue and local hierarchy

LEGAL TERMS -> kharaj + ushr + zakat + jizya + khams + varied cesses
PRACTICE -> assessment, exemptions, cash/kind and collection vary by region
LOCAL ELITES -> khuts + muqaddams + chaudhuris + chiefs + accountants
ALAUDDIN -> measurement, khalisa expansion and pressure on privileges
TUGHLAQs -> sharing, official yields, canals and changing incidence
OUTCOME -> surplus transfer plus uneven burden, flight and resistance
METHOD: distinguish legal category, nominal rate and lived collection.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Army, logistics and urban regulation

HORSES / REMOUNTS -> import routes, branding, inspection and fodder
CASH SALARIES -> coin supply, price conditions and treasury capacity
FORTS / ROADS -> frontier defence, messengers and grain movement
MARKET OVERSIGHT -> weights, supplies, intelligence and punishment
KOTWAL / QAZI -> policing and judicial plurality in towns
LESSON: military power rested on fiscal, commercial and informational systems.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Agrarian surplus and irrigation

RAIN + WELLS + LIFTS + CANALS -> variable cultivation capacity
|
grain and cash crops -> village consumption + dues + marketable surplus
|
state, iqta holder and intermediaries compete over extraction
|
town demand and armies grow, while famine and harsh collection expose risk
CAUTION: public works did not distribute gains equally.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Coinage and monetisation evidence

TANKA / JITTAL -> units and denominations in an expanding money economy
GOLD / SILVER / COPPER -> metal range, scarcity and regional variation
MINTS / LEGENDS -> authority, titles and public monetary claims
CASH REVENUE / SALARY -> links countryside, treasury, army and merchants
RBI PAGE -> official museum synthesis, not a complete price or welfare series
VERDICT: monetisation expanded unevenly; barter and payment in kind persisted.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Urban craft and technology circuit

COURT + ARMY + MERCHANT DEMAND
|
DELHI / DAULATABAD / MULTAN / CAMBAY and smaller qasbas
|
textiles + paper + metal + leather + building crafts + royal karkhanas
|
spinning wheel, carder's bow, improved looms, mortar and water lifting
RESULT: greater output and specialisation without equal gains for labour.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Trade, transport and credit

VILLAGE PRODUCERS -> banjaras and local markets -> inland towns
MULTANIS / SAHS / BROKERS -> advances, exchange and merchant finance
HUNDIS -> transfer and credit across distance
CAMBAY / BENGAL PORTS -> Indian Ocean exchange and textile exports
HORSE IMPORTS -> military demand links coast, merchants and court
LIMIT: route activity does not prove uniform prosperity or state control.
CLOSE DISTINCTION: An iqta was not automatically private ownership or hereditary property
across every reign and region.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Social differentiation without static blocs

ELITES -> mamluk/freeborn Turk + Khalji + Afghan + Tajik + Indian Muslim
RELIGIOUS -> ulama + Sufis + temples/mosques + plural local practice
ECONOMY -> merchants + artisans + peasants + intermediaries + labourers
VARNA / JATI -> occupational continuity, adaptation, mobility and exclusion
SLAVERY -> military + domestic + productive forms; not one Atlantic analogy
GENDER -> elite/property/household and common labour agency differ
RULE: Hindu and Muslim societies were neither sealed nor homogeneous blocs.
EVIDENCE LIMIT: Administrative ideals, chronicler prescriptions and uneven local practice must
remain analytically separate.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Topic 07 evidence and answer spine

OPEN -> changing military-fiscal state, centralising in aspiration
ADMIN -> court + departments + iqta + local intermediaries
ECONOMY -> agrarian surplus + money + towns + crafts + trade
SOCIETY -> layered elites, labour, caste, community, slavery and gender
METHOD -> chroniclers + travellers + coins + inscriptions + monuments
CLOSE -> negotiated in practice, regionally uneven and socially unequal.